A dissertation in film and philosophy



Goat Song in the Laboratory

Reductio in Carne, Stipulative Sovereignty, and the Sacrificial Anthropology of Yorgos Lanthimos

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Every stipulation can be satisfied only by substitution; every substitution is a sacrifice; every sacrifice leaves a remainder; and the remainder is the only exit the enclosure admits.

The Goat Theorem

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the cinema of Yorgos Lanthimos, from *Kinetta* (2005) to *Bugonia* (2025), constitutes a sustained philosophical practice whose unit of argument is neither the allegory nor the image but the *reductio in carne*: a demonstration by absurdity conducted in flesh. Each film stipulates a *nomic novum* — not, in Darko Suvin's sense, a technological innovation validated by cognitive logic, but a law, a lexicon, or a rule of exchange decreed by fiat — encloses it within an immunitary sphere (a walled garden, a hotel, a court, a laboratory-household, a basement), and follows it with deductive fidelity until its founding violence becomes visible as sacrifice, that is, as the substitution of one body for another. The procedure refutes nothing. What it yields is a remainder: an excess of body over rule that erupts as dance, animality, ingestion, bleeding, and laughter, and that the dissertation names, after the contested etymology of *tragōidia*, the goat.

Four mechanisms organize the corpus. *Stipulative sovereignty* extends Carl Schmitt's decisionism from the exception to the definition: sovereign is whoever decides what words mean, a thesis traced from the *nomothetēs* of Plato's *Cratylus* through Hobbes to Derrida's "mystical foundation of authority." The *autoimmune sphere*, assembled from Sloterdijk, Esposito, and Derrida, names enclosures that protect life by destroying what they protect. *Sacrificial substitution*, reconstructed from Robertson Smith, Hubert and Mauss, Meuli, Burkert, Girard, and Bataille, is shown to be the hidden operator of Lanthimosian fungibility, from the bereavement economy of *Alps* to the recasting logic of *Kinds of Kindness*. The *anthropological machine* (Agamben) is literalized in a bestiary of dogs, deer, rabbits, lobsters, goats, and bees through which the films renegotiate Aristotle's partition of beast, human, and god.

Situating these mechanisms within a genealogy that runs from Attic tragedy and sacrificial ritual through Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Freud, Wittgenstein, Artaud, Adorno and Horkheimer, Foucault, Castoriadis, and Deleuze, and reading the films against the Menippean and speculative tradition (Lucian, Swift, Voltaire, Kafka, Zamyatin, Huxley, Borges, Jackson, Le Guin, Ishiguro) and the cinemas of Buñuel, Pasolini, Bresson, Kubrick, and Haneke, the dissertation advances three claims. First, style is argument: the deadpan is the affect of deduction, the sound a premise makes when it is followed without mercy. Second, the corpus describes an arc from *Bouphonia* to *Bugonia*, from the Athenian ox-slaying whose "comedy of innocence" condemned the knife in place of the killer to the ancient belief that bees are born from the carcass of a slaughtered ox, a belief that *Bugonia* turns upon humanity itself. Third, the corpus constitutes a tragedy after the laboratory, in which *anankē* is

refounded on fiat and the gods are replaced by protocols that bind even those who decree them. *Poor Things* (2023) is read as the corpus's kynic exception, a *Candide* in which the experimental subject becomes the experimenter, yet whose closing garden, grazed by a man given a goat's brain, reinstitutes the sacrifice it seemed to abolish. The dissertation concludes by demonstrating, in the geometrical order of Spinoza, a Goat Theorem: every stipulation can be satisfied only by substitution; every substitution is a sacrifice; every sacrifice leaves a remainder; and the remainder is the only exit the enclosure admits.



Prolegomenon

The Axiom and the Goat

I The Problem
II Corpus and Periodization
III Method: The Moderate Bold Thesis
IV Argument, Coinages, Architecture

I The Problem

Criticism of Yorgos Lanthimos has oscillated between two protocols, each of which dissolves the object it proposes to explain. The first is allegoresis. *Dogtooth* (2009) becomes a parable of the authoritarian family, of a nation sealed against the world on the eve of its sovereign-debt crisis, or of patriarchal pedagogy as such; *The Lobster* (2015) becomes a satire of algorithmic matchmaking; *Bugonia* (2025) a diagnosis of conspiratorial politics. Allegoresis is not false, but it is structurally belated: it treats each film as a cipher whose meaning lies elsewhere, and its surface as the husk to be discarded once the message has been extracted. The second protocol is the formalist diagnosis of tone. The films are catalogued by their mannerisms — affectless line readings, wide-angle distortion, atonal scoring, abrupt violence — and the "weirdness" that gave the Greek Weird Wave its name (Rose 2011) is treated as a signature rather than as a thought. Formalism takes the surface seriously, but mistakes it for ornament.

This dissertation begins from the contrary premise: in Lanthimos, style is argument. The flatness of the voice, the geometry of the frame, and the arbitrariness of the rule are not vehicles by which a meaning is conveyed but operations by which a proposition is tested. The films do not assert that institutions are arbitrary; they institute an arbitrary rule and observe, with an experimenter's patience, what it does to bodies over time. Their meaning is therefore procedural, and a procedure cannot be paraphrased without loss, any more than a proof can be replaced by its conclusion. Lanthimos's well-known reluctance to gloss his films is, on this account, less coyness than consistency: the reticence of a demonstrator who knows that what can be shown cannot be said (Wittgenstein 1921, 4.1212). The critic's task is accordingly not to decode the demonstration but to reconstruct it — to identify its axioms, follow its steps, and measure what it leaves unaccounted for.

II Corpus and Periodization

The corpus comprises nine features directed by Lanthimos alone, a commercial comedy co-directed at the outset of his career, and two short films. Its prehistory lies in advertising, music video, and theater, and above all in his participation in the creative team, led by the choreographer Dimitris Papaioannou, that staged the opening and closing ceremonies of the 2004 Athens Olympic Games: an apprenticeship in the mass choreography of bodies whose negative image — the solitary, uncoordinated, embarrassing dance — recurs throughout the mature work. *My Best Friend* (2001), co-directed with Lakis Lazopoulos, belongs to the national popular cinema and marks the boundary against which the corpus defines itself. *Kinetta* (2005) is its primal scene. In an off-season seaside hotel, a plainclothes policeman, a chambermaid, and a man with a video camera restage murders according to a script whose authority is never explained. Every later film repeats the configuration: bodies rehearsing violence under an unexplained rule, observed by an apparatus.

Three phases follow. The *Athenian phase* comprises *Dogtooth* and *Alps* (2011), written with Efthimis Filippou and photographed by Thimios Bakatakis; it forms the nucleus of what Steve Rose's (2011) journalism christened the Greek Weird Wave, subsequently theorized as a biopolitical cinema of family and nation in crisis (Karalis 2012; Psaras 2016; Papanikolaou 2021). The *Anglophone-Filippou phase* comprises *The Lobster* and *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* (2017), in which the nomic novum is scaled up first to the society and then to the cosmos. The *expansive phase* comprises *The Favourite* (2018), written by Deborah Davis and Tony McNamara; *Poor Things* (2023), McNamara's adaptation of Alasdair Gray's novel (Gray 1992); *Kinds of Kindness* (2024), a return to Filippou; and *Bugonia*, Will Tracy's adaptation of Jang Joon-hwan's *Save the Green Planet!* (2003). This phase consolidates a repertory: Robbie Ryan's photography, Jerskin Fendrix's scores, and Emma Stone as recurrent performer and, from *Poor Things* onward, producer. The shorts *Nimic* (2019) and *Bleat* (2022) serve as miniature laboratories in which the corpus's operations appear with the clarity of isolation. *Bugonia* remains the most recent feature at the time of writing, and the corpus closes there.

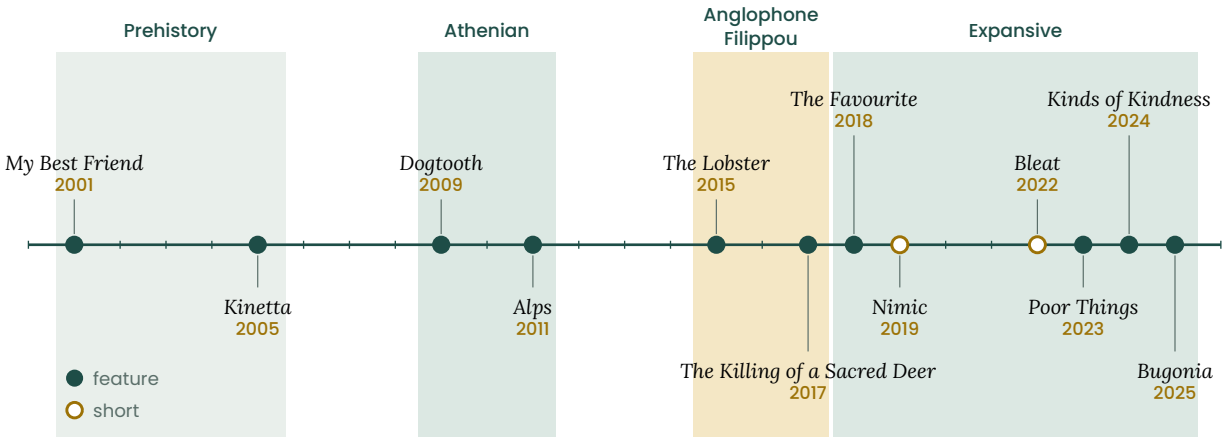


Figure 1. The corpus, 2001–2025: a prehistory and three phases of the reductio in carne.

Collaboration raises the question of the author. Foucault's (1969) author-function — a principle of grouping, coherence, and limitation rather than a psychological origin — suits the case exactly. “Lanthimos” designates a procedure rather than a proprietor, and the decisive evidence for this dissertation's thesis is that the procedure survives the change of writers. McNamara's arch epigrams and Tracy's genre plotting are submitted to the same sequence of stipulation, enclosure, substitution, and remainder as Filippou's scripts. The argument belongs to the form.

III Method: The Moderate Bold Thesis

The philosophy of film has disputed whether films can do philosophy or only illustrate it. Mulhall (2002) proposed that certain films philosophize in action, reflecting on their own conditions with a rigor comparable to argument; Wartenberg (2007) specified that films can screen thought experiments, illustrate theories, and furnish counterexamples. Livingston (2006) formulated the strongest version of the claim — the "bold thesis" that films can make independent and innovative contributions to philosophy by exclusively cinematic means — and posed its dilemma. If the contribution can be paraphrased, it is not exclusively cinematic; if it cannot, it is unclear in what sense it contributes to philosophy.

This dissertation defends a moderate bold thesis. Lanthimos's films contribute to philosophy a premise that philosophical thought experiments systematically suppress: the body and its duration. The verbal thought experiment is weightless and instantaneous. The trolley's lever is pulled in a clause; the teletransporter operates between two sentences; the experience machine is entered without anyone having to lie down. Dennett (2013) calls such devices intuition pumps and recommends turning their knobs to discover which features drive the intuition. Lanthimos turns the one knob philosophers hold fixed, which is embodiment. What becomes of the trolley problem when the chooser must spin blindfolded in his own living room, his family bound and gagged around him, and fire until someone dies? The premise discovered by such a scene can be stated, which secures its philosophical status; but it can be discovered only by being performed, which secures its cinematic necessity. Livingston's dilemma is dissolved rather than refuted: what cinema contributes is not a conclusion but a premise, and premises are found before they are formulated. Deleuze's formula for the modern cinema, "give me a body then" (Deleuze 1985), names the operation precisely: the body is that which forces thought to think what it does not yet think. Cavell (1971) had already described the film image as a moving image of skepticism, a world viewed from which the viewer is absent; the Lanthimosian frame, with its fisheye curvature and surveillant distance, turns Cavell's skeptical camera into the observation window of a laboratory.

IV Argument, Coinages, Architecture

The argument requires a small lexicon of its own, which the chapters justify. A *nomic novum* is a Suvinian novum (Suvin 1979) whose content is a rule rather than a device: the novelty of *The Lobster* is not a transformation technology, whose workings the film never shows, but a regulation. The coinage recovers the Sophistic distinction between *physis* and *nomos*; the Lanthimosian rule is *nomos* presenting itself as *physis*, convention disguised as nature. *Stipulative sovereignty* designates the power to decide what words mean. The *autoimmune sphere* designates the enclosure in which the nomic novum is incubated and which, in protecting its inhabitants, turns upon them. *Sacrificial substitution* designates the operation by which a stipulation is satisfied: the giving of one body in place of

another. The *remainder*, or *goat*, designates what in the body exceeds the stipulation it is made to satisfy. The figure comes from the disputed etymology of *tragōidia*, which Burkert (1966) read as the song performed at the sacrifice of a goat; tragedy, on this reading, is the song of what remains when the victim has been given. The *reductio in carne* designates the procedure as a whole: the assumption of a stipulation within a sphere, followed through bodies until its founding violence appears as substitution.

Hence the title's formula. Attic tragedy staged *anankē*, a necessity rooted in the cosmos and administered by gods. The Lanthimosian corpus stages a necessity refounded on fiat: the rule is arbitrary, but once stipulated it binds with the force of fate, and it binds its sovereigns as well as its subjects. The laboratory is the modern successor of the sanctuary, the place where protocols replace oracles; a goat song in the laboratory is a tragedy after the laboratory.

The dissertation proceeds in five movements. Chapters One and Two treat the rule and its space: the lexicon through which stipulative sovereignty operates, and the household-sphere in which it is incubated. Chapters Three and Four treat the procedure and its price: the thought experiment incarnated, and the sacrifice that incarnation exacts. Chapters Five and Six treat the anthropological and familial consequences: the machine that sorts beast, human, and god, and the machine that manufactures kinship. Chapters Seven and Eight treat the aesthetic and the exception: the an-aesthetics of the deadpan, and *Poor Things* as the experiment that experiments upon itself. Chapters Nine and Ten treat genealogy and ending: the Menippean tradition to which the corpus belongs, and *Bugonia* as the terminal experiment in which the laboratory becomes the cosmos. A Coda demonstrates the Goat Theorem in the geometrical order.

Chapter One

The Nomothete's Lexicon

Stipulative Sovereignty and the Politics of Definition

1.1 The Name-Giver in the Garden
1.2 Heteronomy and the Name “Bruce”
1.3 Language-Games in the Laboratory
1.4 Performatives and Defining Characteristics
1.5 Neologism and the Glossary of Suspicion
1.6 Result

1.1 The Name-Giver in the Garden

Plato's *Cratylus* stages a dispute between Cratylus, for whom names belong to things by nature, and Hermogenes, for whom they are fixed by convention and agreement. Socrates' mediation introduces a figure who will preoccupy this chapter: the *nomothetēs*, the lawgiver or name-maker, the rarest of craftsmen, to whom the institution of names is entrusted (*Cratylus* 388e–389a). The name-giver is at once linguist and legislator; in naming, he legislates.

Dogtooth installs this figure in a suburban villa. The father's instrument is a set of audio tapes that define words for his children: “sea” is a leather armchair, “motorway” a very strong wind, “excursion” a highly resistant material used for floors, “carbine” a beautiful white bird, “zombie” a small yellow flower; elsewhere “telephone” names the salt shaker. The lexicon is not random. The terms it redefines belong to the vocabulary of exit — the sea, the motorway, the excursion, and the telephone are the names of departure, travel, and communication with the outside — and each is folded back onto the furniture of the interior. The operation is an enclosure act conducted within the signifier: before the fence surrounds the garden, the definition surrounds the word. Where the outside cannot be denied it is domesticated. The airplanes that pass overhead become toys that “fall” into the garden, and the most dangerous creature in the world is a cat.

Saussure's (1916) doctrine of the arbitrariness of the sign here becomes a political technology. If the bond between signifier and signified is unmotivated, whoever controls the *langue* controls the world available to its speakers. Carroll's Humpty Dumpty had already drawn the conclusion: the question is not what words mean but “which is to be master” (Carroll 1871). Hobbes drew it with juridical seriousness, holding that truth and falsity are attributes of speech rather than of things and that the sovereign, as arbiter of controversies, must settle the meaning of contested names (Hobbes 1651). Schmitt's (1922) definition — sovereign is he who decides on the exception — can therefore be extended without distortion: sovereign is he who decides on the definition. This is stipulative sovereignty. Its founding act is neither true nor false. To say that “sea” means armchair is not to describe but to institute; it is what Derrida (1990), following Montaigne and Pascal, called the “mystical foundation of authority,” a performative violence that grounds the law and cannot itself be grounded in it.

1.2 Heteronomy and the Name “Bruce”

Stipulative sovereignty conceals its own operation. Castoriadis (1975) distinguished heteronomous societies, which attribute their institution to an extra-social source (gods, ancestors, nature, history), from autonomous ones, which recognize themselves as self-instituting. The father of *Dogtooth* manufactures heteronomy on a domestic scale. His rules are presented as natural facts: a child may leave home when a canine tooth falls out, and may drive once it has grown back; a brother lives beyond the fence; the mother will give birth to two children and a dog. The origin of the rules is displaced into biology and fate, exactly as

Castoriadis's heteronomous societies displace theirs into the sacred.

Against this, the elder daughter's demand, after her exposure to contraband videocassettes, to be called by a new name, Bruce, is the corpus's first act of autonomous institution: a name with no warrant in the paternal lexicon, chosen rather than received. Yet the act is compromised in the gesture that makes it possible. It draws on a second lexicon, the world of cinema, whose sovereignty the daughter has merely exchanged for her father's; she recites scenes from *Rocky* and *Jaws* as scripture. Autonomy, in Lanthimos, first appears as the choice of one's heteronomy.

1.3 Language-Games in the Laboratory

Wittgenstein's builders (Wittgenstein 1953, §2) possess a language of four words — block, pillar, slab, beam — which is complete for their purposes; to imagine a language, he wrote, is to imagine a form of life (§19). *Dogtooth* is an experimental realization of the builders' scenario: a primitive language adequate to a form of life that has been engineered to fit it. The *Tractatus* proposition that the limits of my language mean the limits of my world (Wittgenstein 1921, 5.6) is literalized with deadpan exactitude; the film adds only that the limits of the world are also a fence, a gate, and a father's car. The tapes, with their definitions followed by model sentences, belong to the genre of the language primer, and here the corpus meets its theatrical ancestor. Ionesco built *The Bald Soprano* from the model sentences of an English phrasebook, discovering in them the absurdity latent in all rule-bound speech (Ionesco 1950).

The private-language remarks illuminate the notorious Lanthimosian voice. Wittgenstein's beetle in the box (§293), the private object that drops out of consideration as irrelevant to the public use of the word, describes the performance style of the corpus with uncanny precision. Characters name their emotional states with the neutrality of a weather report; they announce love, grief, desire, and sorrow as entries in a register, and the naming does not express an interior so much as certify its administrative existence. The deadpan is not the absence of feeling. It is feeling after the beetle has dropped out: the inner state reduced to the public criterion the rule demands.

1.4 Performatives and Defining Characteristics

Austin (1962) distinguished constative utterances, which are true or false, from performatives, which accomplish what they say when their felicity conditions obtain. Butler (1990; 1997) extended performativity to identity itself, understood as the sedimented reiteration of norms that retroactively produces the subject it appears to express. *The Lobster* transforms this theory into an administrative procedure. In the Hotel each guest is reduced to a single "defining characteristic" — a limp, a propensity to nosebleeds, short-sightedness, heartlessness — and couples are matched by shared characteristics. Identity is a performative that requires ratification, and the ratification is corporeal. The man with the limp, pursuing a woman prone to nosebleeds, secretly strikes his face against hard

surfaces to produce the matching blood. David, courting a woman defined by heartlessness, feigns heartlessness until the test arrives in the form of his brother, a dog, kicked to death; his grief betrays him.

The scene yields the second axiom of this dissertation: words do not bleed, bodies do. Every performative in the corpus eventually requires a body to underwrite it, and every stipulation seeks its ratification in blood. The Hotel's paperwork is complete; what it lacks is flesh, and it extracts flesh from its guests with a regularity that is itself procedural. Couples who cannot resolve their quarrels are assigned a child: the felicity conditions of the couple include a third body. The loners in the woods do not escape this logic; they invert it. Their leader's prohibition of flirtation produces a counter-lexicon, the gestural code through which David and the Short Sighted Woman signal desire and danger, and the code reproduces the structure it opposes. Every private language is also an enclosure, a sphere of two.

The same holds for the exterior of *Dogtooth*. The outside enters the villa first as commodity and then as cinema. Christina, the factory security guard whom the father pays to have sex with his son, trades her headband to the elder daughter in exchange for oral sex, and later videocassettes on the same terms. Barter introduces equivalence, and equivalence introduces a new lexicon. The counter-languages of the corpus do not liberate; they replace one sovereign with another — the market, Hollywood, the couple, the sect.

1.5 Neologism and the Glossary of Suspicion

Two later films test the thesis at its limits. In *Poor Things* Bella Baxter's acquisition of language compresses into months what Vico (1744) assigned to ages: the first humans, he argued, named the world through poetic metaphor, a poetic wisdom preceding the abstract categories of reason. Bella's neologisms, above all “furious jumping” for sexual intercourse, are Vichian metaphors, and they mark the corpus's first genuine counter-example to stipulative sovereignty. Naming here is discovery rather than decree. Bella does not fold the outside onto the interior but extends the interior toward an outside it has not yet mapped, and the film's exceptional status, examined in Chapter Eight, begins in its philology.

Bugonia sets two lexicons at war. On one side stands corporate euphemism, the managerial idiom of wellness and inclusion through which Michelle Fuller administers her pharmaceutical company; on the other stands Teddy Gatz's conspiracist glossary of Andromedans, motherships, and signals transmitted through hair. Hofstadter (1964) observed that the paranoid style is characteristically pedantic, heavily documented and obsessively coherent, and Sedgwick (2003) described paranoid reading as a strong theory that explains everything in advance. Teddy is a nomothete of the paranoid kind, and his lexicon is as total as the father's in *Dogtooth*. The film's late turn complicates the pattern, since within the fiction the glossary appears to be vindicated. The vindication does not redeem stipulation; it completes it. A definition that turns out to be true has not ceased to be a definition, and the violence it licensed is not retroactively

justified by its accuracy.

1.6 Result

Language in Lanthimos is not representation but jurisdiction. A word is a border, a definition a fence, and the first form of the nomic novum is the stipulated meaning. The films expose the arbitrariness of stipulation without ever disproving it, because a definition cannot be refuted; it can only be obeyed, evaded, or bled for. What remains to be explained is the space in which such definitions can be enforced: the sphere.

Chapter Two

Oikonomia

The Household, the Sphere, and the Autoimmune Enclosure

2.1 An Inventory of Enclosures
2.2 Oikos against Polis
2.3 Heterotopia, Total Institution, Token Economy
2.4 Spheres and the Autoimmune Turn
2.5 Fences, Trunks, and Foam

2.1 An Inventory of Enclosures

Every Lanthimos film is set in a closed system. *Kinetta* confines its reenactments to a hotel emptied by the off-season. *Dogtooth* is bounded by a high fence and a swimming pool. *Alps* moves between a gymnasium and the rented interiors of the dead. *The Lobster* is organized around a hotel, a forest, and a city, each governed by its own regime. *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* oscillates between a hospital and a suburban house, and the house becomes a quarantine. *The Favourite* rarely leaves the precincts of a palace in which a war is conducted from a bedchamber. *Poor Things* begins in a house its ward is forbidden to leave, and continues aboard a ship and in a brothel. *Kinds of Kindness* nests three enclosures: a corporate patronage, a police marriage, a sect's compound. *Bugonia* descends into a basement. The recurrence is not a matter of budget or taste. The nomic novum requires a sealed space in which its premise can be incubated without interference, as the experimental method requires the isolation of variables. The Lanthimosian enclosure is a laboratory whose form is a household.

2.2 Oikos against Polis

Aristotle opens the *Politics* by distinguishing the household (*oikos*), the domain of necessity and of unequal rule, from the city (*polis*), the domain of freedom and of rule among equals. Within the household the master rules the slave despotically, the husband rules the wife politically, and the father rules the children royally (*Politics* 1259a–b). The Lanthimosian enclosures are polities collapsed into households. The Hotel of *The Lobster* is a state administered as a domestic economy, rationing days of human life as a housekeeper rations provisions. The court of *The Favourite* conducts foreign policy through the bedchamber. The corporate world of the first story of *Kinds of Kindness* is a household in which the patron dictates his employee's meals, his clothes, when he has sex with his wife, and whether the couple may have children: Raymond has arranged for Sarah to be given abortifacients, so that her pregnancies end in what she is told are miscarriages, and Robert has kept the secret.

Agamben (2007) has argued that *oikonomia*, the administration of the household, became through Christian theology the paradigm of modern government: governance as management, sovereignty as housekeeping. Lanthimos stages the result. His rulers do not command in the name of law but manage in the name of welfare; their violence arrives as care. The historical conjuncture of the Athenian phase sharpens the reading. The European sovereign-debt crisis was widely narrated through the metaphor of the household budget — the proverbial Swabian housewife invoked in German debate as a model of fiscal prudence — and critics of the Greek Weird Wave have read the family of *Dogtooth* as the biopolitical figure of a nation disciplined through domestic economy (Psaras 2016; Papanikolaou 2021). Yet the film premiered at Cannes in 2009, before the crisis reached its full force. It is better understood not as an allegory of the crisis but as its anticipatory form: the discovery that when the polis withdraws, the household

is the only polity left, and that the household governs more totally than any state.

2.3 Heterotopia, Total Institution, Token Economy

Foucault's lecture on heterotopias (Foucault 1984) supplies a typology for these spaces. Heterotopias of crisis shelter those in transition — adolescents, women in childbirth, the newlywed couple whose honeymoon must take place nowhere — and heterotopias of deviation contain those whose behavior departs from the norm. The Hotel of *The Lobster* fuses the two. It is a honeymoon hotel for the unmarried, a sanatorium in which singleness is treated as a condition requiring cure within forty-five days. Foucault called the ship the heterotopia par excellence, a floating place without a place, and counted the brothel among the heterotopias of illusion; *Poor Things* passes through both, which is to say that its emancipatory journey is conducted from one heterotopia to the next.

The triadic geography of *The Lobster* can be read with unusual precision. The Hotel is a disciplinary society in Foucault's (1975) sense: timetables, examinations, surveillance, and the normalizing judgment that divides the coupled from the single. The Woods are its mirror, an anti-disciplinary discipline in which the prohibition of love is as absolute as the obligation to love in the Hotel, enforced by mutilating penalties whose names parody romance; the “red kiss” slits the lips of those caught flirting. The City is the society of control that Deleuze (1990) saw succeeding discipline: no walls, only checkpoints, and officers who stop a man walking alone in a shopping mall to ask whether he is partnered. The film's three spaces recapitulate a genealogy of power from confinement to modulation.

Goffman's (1961) account of the total institution fits the Hotel point by point: the surrender of personal effects on admission, identical clothing, a privilege system that rewards compliance with extra days for every loner brought down with a tranquilizer dart, and the mortification of self exemplified by the hand bound behind a guest's back to teach him how much easier life is with two. The Hotel's pedagogy includes staged skits on the perils of solitude: a man eating alone chokes, a woman walking alone is attacked by a would-be rapist, and with a partner both are spared. In *Dogtooth* the regime is behaviorist. The children compete in endurance games for stickers, a token economy of the kind Skinner (1948) imagined for *Walden Two* and later clinical practice institutionalized. Zamyatin's Table of Hours in *We* (Zamyatin 1924), which synchronized every citizen's day, is the literary ancestor of both schedules.

2.4 Spheres and the Autoimmune Turn

Sloterdijk's *Spheres* (1998) begins not with the city or the state but with the dyad: the microsphere of intimacy, of which mother and fetus are the paradigm, a bubble of shared interiority prior to any subject and object. *Poor Things* literalizes the dyad with surgical exactness. Bella is a woman whose skull contains the brain of the child she was carrying when she drowned herself; mother and child occupy one body, a sphere folded upon itself with no partner outside it. The film's emblem is appropriately Godwin Baxter's digestive bubbles, which rise from his mouth as a

by-product of his own father's experiments upon him: the scientist exhales spheres.

Esposito (1998; 2002) has shown that *communitas* and *immunitas* share a root in *munus*, the obligation or gift. Community binds its members by a debt; immunity exempts from it. Modern politics, on his account, protects life by negating it in controlled doses, on the model of the vaccine. The lexicon of *Dogtooth* is a vaccine against the outside. The word "sea" is admitted, but in attenuated form, as an armchair; airplanes are admitted, as toys. The outside is not excluded but incorporated in a weakened dose that confers immunity.

Derrida (1996; 2003) named the pathological limit of this logic autoimmunity: the process by which a living being destroys its own protections, attacking itself as though it were foreign. Every Lanthimosian sphere becomes autoimmune. In *Dogtooth* the cat that strays into the garden, the only living visitor from outside, is killed with shears by the son; the father then announces that a cat has killed the brother beyond the fence, and the family learns to bark on all fours. When the paid outsider is expelled, the sphere's immunity turns inward, and exogamy is replaced by incest. At last the elder daughter smashes her own canine tooth with a dumbbell to satisfy the rule of exit: the body attacks its own organ in order to obey the law of the enclosure. In *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* the family's immune response to the intruder — Steven's imprisonment of Martin in the basement — fails because the pathology is not an infection but a debt. In *The Lobster* the Hotel immunizes against solitude by producing couples who must counterfeit themselves.

2.5 Fences, Trunks, and Foam

Rousseau (1755) located the origin of civil society in the first man who, having enclosed a plot of ground, thought of saying "this is mine" and found people simple enough to believe him. The fence of *Dogtooth* is Rousseau's primal enclosure restaged as parenthood. Its exit, however, is no return to nature. The elder daughter escapes into the trunk of her father's car, a smaller enclosure within the vehicle of the sovereign, and the film ends on the closed trunk. Kafka's ape in "A Report to an Academy" (Kafka 1917) insists that he never sought freedom, only a way out; the trunk is a way out, not a freedom. Enclosure in Lanthimos is recursive: the exit from one sphere is the entrance to another.

Sloterdijk (2004) described modern society as foam, an aggregate of co-isolated cells that share walls without sharing an interior. The corpus as a whole is such a foam, and *Kinds of Kindness*, whose three stories share actors as cells share membranes, is its most explicit formal image. *Bugonia* ends the series by bursting it. In the film's closing movement the fate of humanity is figured as the pricking of a bubble, and the sphere that had been the corpus's condition of possibility is punctured at planetary scale. The result of this chapter can be stated as a law: the nomic novum requires a sphere, and every sphere, in protecting what it encloses, turns against it.

Chapter Three

Reductio in Carne

The Thought Experiment Incarnate

3.1 The Imaginary Case and Its Missing Premise
3.2 The Forbidden Experiment
3.3 Trolley, Veil, Lottery: The Killing of a Sacred Deer
3.4 Aristophanes' Myth under Administrative Law: The Lobster
3.5 Personal Identity in the Flesh
3.6 Obedience, the Experience Machine, the Penal Colony

3.1 The Imaginary Case and Its Missing Premise

Sorensen (1992) defined the thought experiment as an experiment that purports to achieve its aim without the benefit of execution. Gendler (2000) argued that such experiments work by mobilizing tacit knowledge through imagined particulars, eliciting judgments that abstract reasoning cannot reach. Dennett (2013) proposed, more skeptically, that many are intuition pumps whose outputs depend on the setting of knobs the reader never notices. On every account the defining privilege of the thought experiment is exemption from execution. Nobody need be pushed from a footbridge; nobody need be copied and destroyed.

The *reductio ad absurdum* shares this privilege. It assumes a proposition, derives consequences, and rejects the proposition when a contradiction appears; the absurdity is logical, and it costs nothing. The Lanthimosian procedure revokes the exemption. It assumes a stipulation, derives its consequences through bodies, and discovers that the terminus is not contradiction but flesh: a smashed tooth, a severed thumb, a paralyzed child, eyes that bleed. This is the *reductio in carne*. Its three additions to the imaginary case are duration, resistance, and fluid. Duration: the action takes time, and the time is awkward, repetitive, embarrassing. Resistance: bodies do not execute premises smoothly; they limp, stall, and refuse. Fluid: the demonstration leaks — blood, saliva, vomit, tears, and, in the diner scenes that close two of the films, sauce.

3.2 The Forbidden Experiment

The oldest thought experiment about language was, according to Herodotus, actually performed. The pharaoh Psammetichus, wishing to learn which people was the most ancient, had two infants raised by a shepherd forbidden to speak in their presence; their first word, *bekos*, was identified as Phrygian for bread (Herodotus 2.2). The chronicler Salimbene reported that Frederick II repeated the experiment and that the children died. The Enlightenment turned the forbidden experiment into the problem of the wild child — Itard's (1801) report on Victor of Aveyron, the case of Kaspar Hauser in Nuremberg — and cinema followed with Truffaut's *L'Enfant sauvage* (1970) and Herzog's *The Enigma of Kaspar Hauser* (1974). Skinner (1948) transposed the experiment into utopia: *Walden Two* is a community in which behavior is engineered from infancy by positive reinforcement.

Dogtooth is the forbidden experiment performed as parenting, and it inverts the experiment's purpose. Psammetichus sought the natural origin of language by withholding culture; the father of *Dogtooth* withholds the world in order to manufacture an artificial origin. His children are not wild but over-domesticated, raised within a culture so complete that it has no outside. *Poor Things* inverts the experiment a second time. Mary Shelley's Creature acquires language by eavesdropping on the De Lacey family (Shelley 1818); Bella acquires it in the open, among teachers, lovers, and books, and eventually turns the experiment upon her experimenters. She is the forbidden experiment consenting, belatedly, to be

conducted — and then conducting it.

3.3 Trolley, Veil, Lottery: The Killing of a Sacred Deer

Foot (1967) introduced the case of the driver of a runaway tram who can steer onto a track where one person will die instead of five; Thomson (1976; 1985) multiplied its variants into the trolley problem and asked what distinguishes permissible from impermissible killing. *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* reconstructs the problem with one decisive alteration. Martin, whose father died on the operating table of the cardiac surgeon Steven Murphy, informs Steven that his family will succumb in sequence to paralysis of the legs, refusal of food, bleeding from the eyes, and death, unless Steven kills one of them himself. The dilemma is structurally a trolley problem — one death or several — but the chooser stands inside the case, the one to be killed is kin, and the choice must be executed by hand.

The film then tests, one after another, the procedures that moral philosophy offers for such choices. Steven attempts a merit calculus, visiting his children's school to ask the principal which of the two is the better student; the answer is noncommittal. His wife Anna proposes a demographic calculus: they are still young enough to have another child. The children audition for survival. Bob cuts off the long hair his father had nagged him to cut; Kim professes devotion. Every rational procedure fails to issue a verdict, and Steven finally resorts to chance. With a woolen cap pulled over his eyes, he spins in the living room with a rifle while his wife and children sit bound and gagged, and fires until a shot kills his son.

The blindfold is a literal veil of ignorance. Rawls (1971) asked what principles of justice would be chosen by parties deprived of knowledge of their place in the social order; Steven chooses under a deprivation of knowledge of his target. The emblematic history of the blindfold completes the irony. The blindfolded figure of Justice, now the icon of impartiality, first appears in a satirical woodcut in Sebastian Brant's *Ship of Fools* (Brant 1494), in which a fool ties a cloth over Justice's eyes (Resnik and Curtis 2011): the emblem of impartiality began as a mockery of justice's folly. *Sacred Deer* restores the blindfold to its satirical origin. The veil does not produce fairness; it produces a lottery. Jackson's “The Lottery” (Jackson 1948) and Borges's “The Lottery in Babylon” (Borges 1941) had already shown chance institutionalized as a mode of sacrifice. Lanthimos domesticates the lottery into living-room roulette and discovers that at the moment of sacrifice impartiality is indistinguishable from arbitrariness. The trolley's lever becomes a spinning man.

3.4 Aristophanes' Myth under Administrative Law: The Lobster

In Plato's *Symposium* Aristophanes explains love by a myth: primordial humans were double creatures, round, with four arms and four legs, whom Zeus cut in two, so that each half now seeks its other (*Symposium* 189c–193d). *The Lobster* submits the myth to administrative law. The Hotel identifies each guest's other half by a matching characteristic and enforces the search under penalty of metamorphosis. The film then conducts a double reductio. The Hotel's compulsory coupling

collapses into counterfeit, since matching characteristics must be faked; the Woods' compulsory solitude collapses into mutilation, since the loners' leader has the Short Sighted Woman blinded to destroy her attachment to David. The final scene transfers the logic of the matching characteristic from administration to love itself. In a restaurant restroom David raises a steak knife to his eye in order to match the woman he loves, now blind; the film cuts to her waiting at the table, and ends without showing whether he does it.

The ending is aporetic in the precise sense of the early Platonic dialogues. The *Euthyphro* and the *Laches* close without a definition of piety or of courage; *The Lobster* closes without a definition of love, having refuted both the institutional definition (love as matched characteristic) and its negation (love as prohibited attachment). What remains is a body poised to wound itself for the sake of symmetry. Han (2012) has argued that the contemporary crisis of love is the disappearance of the other into a society of the same; Illouz (2007) has traced the rationalization of intimacy under emotional capitalism. *The Lobster* shows the endpoint of both processes: love reduced to similarity demands, at the limit, the mutilation that manufactures similarity.

3.5 Personal Identity in the Flesh

Locke's case of the prince and the cobbler, whose souls exchange bodies (Locke 1694), Putnam's (1981) brain in a vat, and Parfit's (1984) teletransporter test the criteria of personal identity under conditions that cannot be realized. The corpus realizes them. *Alps* treats identity as a role. Its members substitute for the recently dead, learning their phrases, their favorite actors, and their habits in order to perform them for the bereaved, and the nurse at the center of the film comes to prefer the dead girl's life to her own. Identity here is a list of criteria that anyone sufficiently diligent can satisfy.

The second story of *Kinds of Kindness* runs the inverse experiment. Liz, a marine biologist lost at sea, is rescued and returns home, and her husband Daniel, a police officer, becomes convinced that she is an impostor. The premise turns the remarriage comedy of the spouse returned from shipwreck, *My Favorite Wife* (1940), into a horror of verification. The delusion that a familiar person has been replaced by a double was described by Capgras and Reboul-Lachaux (1923) as *l'illusion des sosies*, and its philosophical form is Descartes's remark that what he sees from his window are only hats and coats, which might conceal automata (Descartes 1641). Daniel demands proof, and the proof must be corporeal: he asks Liz to cut off her thumb and cook it for him, and later to cut out her liver and give it to him. Both organs are philosophically charged. The hand, for Aristotle, is the tool of tools (*De Anima* 432a1–2); the liver is the organ of divination, read by haruspices for the will of the gods, and the organ of Promethean punishment. Daniel seeks the truth in the entrails, like a diviner, and Liz complies; the second demand kills her. Compliance proves nothing about identity; it proves only obedience, and here the proof is fatal. Cavell (1979; 1987) read *Othello* as the tragedy of skepticism, in which the demand for ocular proof destroys the person

whose reality it seeks to confirm. The Lanthimosian husband performs Othello's demand as a recipe and, like Othello, destroys the wife whose truth he demanded to see.

Bugonia inverts the test once more. Teddy's interrogation of Michelle seeks to establish that a human being is not human, and his instruments are the shaved head, the chain, the antihistamine cream smeared over her body to block her signals, and the demanded confession. The criteria of humanity are administered by the paranoid.

3.6 Obedience, the Experience Machine, the Penal Colony

Milgram (1974) found that ordinary subjects would administer apparently lethal shocks when instructed by an authority, and theorized an agentic state in which the subject regards himself as the instrument of another's will. The first story of *Kinds of Kindness* is Milgram's experiment extended to an entire life. Robert's existence is scripted by his employer, Raymond, down to its most intimate details; when Raymond orders him to kill a man, R.M.F., by crashing into his car, Robert refuses, and his world collapses in consequence. It is restored only when Robert does kill R.M.F. and Raymond takes him back. Milgram's subjects believed they were inflicting harm and were spared its reality; Robert is not. Arendt (1963) located the moral catastrophe of obedience in thoughtlessness; the story's horror is the converse, the terror of having to think once the script is withdrawn.

Nozick's (1974) experience machine asked whether one would plug into a simulation guaranteeing pleasurable experiences, and assumed that most would refuse. *Alps* describes a market in which the bereaved voluntarily plug into simulations of the dead, knowing them to be simulations, and in which the simulators plug themselves into other people's lives. The machine that philosophers refuse, mourners purchase.

Kafka's “In the Penal Colony” (Kafka 1919) is the ancestor of the entire procedure. Its apparatus inscribes the violated commandment on the condemned man's body, and its officer promises that in the sixth hour the prisoner will decipher the law through his wounds. When the officer submits himself to the machine, it malfunctions and kills him without revelation. The *reductio in carne* shares the apparatus's premise — that the law becomes legible only in flesh — and the malfunction's result. The body bleeds, but the law does not become clear. No Lanthimos ending transfigures; none delivers the promised sixth hour. What the body yields in place of revelation is the subject of the next chapter: sacrifice.

IV

Chapter Four

From Bouphonia to Bugonia

Sacrifice, Substitution, and the Comedy of Innocence

4.1 Theories of Sacrifice
4.2 The Bouphonia and the Anesthesiologist
4.3 Iphigenia without the Deer
4.4 The General Equivalent: Alps and the Market of Substitutes
4.5 Gift, Relic, Munus
4.6 The Sacrificial Meal
4.7 Bugonia: The Ox That Is Humanity

4.1 Theories of Sacrifice

The modern theory of sacrifice begins with Robertson Smith (1889), who read the sacrificial meal as a communion uniting worshippers with their god through the shared flesh of the victim. Hubert and Mauss (1899) replaced communion with mediation: sacrifice consecrates a victim in order to establish communication between the sacred and the profane, and it distinguishes the *sacrifier*, who receives the benefit, from the *sacrificer*, who performs the act. Girard (1972) located the origin of sacrifice in mimetic violence, which threatens to consume the community until it is discharged onto a surrogate victim whose death restores order and whose guilt the community believes in. Burkert (1972) derived sacrifice from the hunt, reading in Greek ritual the anxiety of a species that kills to live and must ritually manage its guilt. Bataille (1949; 1973) understood sacrifice as the destruction of utility: the victim is withdrawn from the world of things and returned to intimacy through a consumption that yields nothing. Nietzsche's second treatise on the genealogy of morals (Nietzsche 1887) supplied the economic underside: guilt (*Schuld*) derives from debt (*Schulden*), and punishment from the creditor's right to an equivalent in pain.

The Lanthimosian synthesis draws on all of these and is reducible to none. Sacrifice in the corpus is substitution under a stipulated equivalence: the giving of one body for another according to a rule that fixes what counts as equal. The rule may be Martin's "justice," the Hotel's matching characteristic, the market price of a performance of the dead, or a patron's will. In every case the equivalence is stipulated, and in every case a body pays.

4.2 The Bouphonia and the Anesthesiologist

At the Athenian festival of the Dipolieia, an ox was allowed to approach the altar of Zeus Polieus and eat the grain laid upon it; it was then struck down, and the man who struck it fled. According to Porphyry (*On Abstinence* 2.29–30), a trial followed in which responsibility was passed down a chain of agents: those who had carried the water blamed those who had sharpened the axe and the knife; these blamed the man who had handed the instruments over; he blamed those who had struck and slaughtered the animal; and they blamed the knife, which was condemned and cast into the sea. The ox was skinned, its hide stuffed, and the effigy yoked to a plough as though the animal had been restored to life. Pausanias (1.24.4; 1.28.10) records the rite and the court in the Prytaneion at which inanimate objects were tried, and in Aristophanes' *Clouds* (984–985) the Bouphonia is already mocked as a relic of antiquated piety. Meuli (1946) called such procedures a *Unschuldskomödie*, a comedy of innocence, and Burkert (1972) made the term central to the theory of Greek sacrifice. The ritual kills the animal and then performs the disavowal of the killing, displacing guilt along a chain of hands until it comes to rest on an instrument.

The Killing of a Sacred Deer restages the comedy of innocence in a hospital. The death of Martin's father on the operating table is surrounded by a displacement of

guilt worthy of the Prytaneion. Steven maintains that an anesthesiologist can kill a patient but a surgeon never can; the anesthesiologist, pressed by Anna, returns the blame to the surgeon, who had been drinking before the operation. Anna obtains this knowledge by masturbating the anesthesiologist in his parked car: the truth of guilt, too, has its price. Martin's intervention is a refusal of the comedy. He demands that the chain of displacement terminate in the one who held the knife, and he formulates the demand as justice, which in his mouth is Nietzsche's creditor's right: a life for a life, equivalence exacted in flesh. The film's final irony is that Steven, compelled to kill, reinstates the comedy by other means. Blindfolded and spinning, he makes chance the knife. Guilt is displaced once more, not onto the anesthesiologist but onto the randomness of the rifle. The Bouphonia's knife has become a lottery.

The first story of *Kinds of Kindness* supplies the comedy's medical form. Sarah's pregnancies are ended on Raymond's instructions and presented to her as miscarriages: a sacrifice of children performed as misfortune, with nature cast in the role of the knife.

4.3 Iphigenia without the Deer

The film's title alludes to the Atreid myth. In the version given in Sophocles' *Electra*, Agamemnon provoked Artemis by killing a stag in her sacred grove and boasting of it, and the goddess demanded his daughter Iphigenia in return. In Euripides' *Iphigenia at Aulis* a messenger reports that at the moment of sacrifice the girl vanished and a deer lay bleeding on the altar in her place; the passage is probably a later addition, but the substitution it describes is ancient. In Genesis 22 a ram caught in a thicket replaces Isaac. Kierkegaard (1843a) read the binding of Isaac as a teleological suspension of the ethical, and Derrida (1992) as the paradigm of a responsibility that must sacrifice the ethical to the absolute and keep the secret of the sacrifice. In each version the divine demand for a human life is answered at the last moment by an animal: the substitution of beast for child is the founding gesture of sacrificial civilization.

The Killing of a Sacred Deer is Iphigenia without the deer. No animal appears on the altar; no angel stays the hand. The founding substitution that separated animal sacrifice from human sacrifice is revoked, and the regression is the source of the film's horror. The film preserves the ritual's other features with scrupulous exactness. Bob's shearing of his hair recalls the Greek offering of hair, the part given for the whole, by which Achilles dedicated his lock to the dead Patroclus (*Iliad* 23.141–153) and Orestes laid his upon his father's tomb in Aeschylus' *Libation Bearers*; hair is the substitute a body can spare. Anna's calculus, that the parents can still conceive, is the modest proposal of a house that has already accepted the sacrificial premise and is negotiating only its price.

The Aeschylean version supplies a further rhyme. In the parodos of the *Agamemnon* the chorus recalls the portent at Aulis: two eagles tearing a pregnant hare together with her unborn young, which provoked the anger of Artemis. *The Favourite* keeps seventeen rabbits in the Queen's chamber, one for each of the

children Anne has lost, and the film's final images superimpose the rabbits over Abigail kneeling at the Queen's feet, after Abigail has pressed her foot upon one of them. Lanthimos's rabbits are the hare's unborn young, surviving as pets and substitutes, and still within reach of the predator's foot.

4.4 The General Equivalent: Alps and the Market of Substitutes

In *Alps* the leader of a clandestine group of mourning-substitutes explains its name: the Alps can replace any other mountain in the world, but no other mountain can replace them. The formula is Marx's (1867) general equivalent, the commodity that expresses the value of all others and is itself excluded from the relative form of value. Simmel (1900) described money as the pure means that renders all things commensurable; Hochschild (1983) described the commodification of feeling as emotional labor. The Alps' service unites the three: it sells substitution, prices grief, and requires its members to perform affect on schedule. The ancient logic of vicarious sacrifice becomes a service economy.

The film's crisis is the substitute's revolt against the general equivalent. The nurse begins to serve the dead girl's parents on her own account, outside the group's jurisdiction and against its rules, and prolongs the role beyond any contract; she wants substitution without equivalence, a gift rather than a sale. The group answers with violence. The short *Nimic* (2019) extracts the logic in its purest form. A cellist asks a stranger on the underground for the time; she begins to repeat his words and gestures, follows him home, and takes his place in his family and his orchestra, and his family accepts her. The Romanian word *nimic* means nothing. The substitute is nothing, and nothing is enough.

Kinds of Kindness raises substitution to the level of form. Its repertory of performers plays different characters in each of three stories, so that an actor who is victim in one story is sacrificer or witness in the next; the triptych is an apparatus of recasting in which fungibility is not a theme but a method of production. One figure alone persists under the same name. R.M.F., played by Yorgos Stefanakos, is killed by Robert in the first story, appears in the second, and in the third is resurrected in a mortuary before, in the film's last scene, he eats a sandwich. He is the sacrificial constant of the triptych, the victim whose identity survives every recasting because his function never changes. The third story's twin sisters complete the pattern. Girard (1972) observed that twins in myth embody the crisis of distinction, the terror of undifferentiation that sacrifice is instituted to resolve. The sect's search for a woman who can raise the dead leads to a pair of identical sisters, and Girard's crisis becomes a plot device: which twin possesses the gift is the whole difference between a miracle and a corpse.

4.5 Gift, Relic, Munus

Mauss (1925) showed that the gift obliges: to give, to receive, and to reciprocate are three obligations, and the unreturned gift subordinates the recipient to the giver. Esposito's (1998) *munus* names the same structure at the foundation of community, and Derrida (1991) argued that a gift recognized as a gift is annulled by the debt it creates. The first story of *Kinds of Kindness* is organized by gifts. Raymond rewards Robert's obedience with sporting memorabilia: a racket broken by John McEnroe, a helmet of Ayrton Senna's. These are relics in the strict sense, remains sanctified by proximity to consecrated bodies — the champion's rage, the driver's death on the circuit — and they bind the recipient by a debt that no counter-gift can discharge. The relic is the remainder of an earlier sacrifice, recirculated as the currency of servitude.

4.6 The Sacrificial Meal

Sacrifice ends in a meal, and the Lanthimosian corpus ends its sacrifices at table. The house of Atreus supplied the archetype: Atreus served Thyestes the flesh of his own children, the crime that Aegisthus recalls at the close of the *Agamemnon* as the origin of the curse. In the second story of *Kinds of Kindness* Liz cooks her own thumb and serves it to Daniel, a Thyestean feast reduced to marital proof. The diner scenes that close *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* and *Kinds of Kindness* complete the ritual. In the first, the surviving family, reduced by one, sits in a roadside diner; Kim pours ketchup over her fries while Martin looks on, and the family leaves without a word. In the second, R.M.F. eats a sandwich and stains his shirt with its red sauce. Ketchup is the Eucharist of the secular sacrifice: blood transubstantiated into condiment, the communion meal of Robertson Smith performed without a god. And in the second case the victim, resurrected, eats; the sacrificial meal is consumed by the sacrificed.

4.7 Bugonia: The Ox That Is Humanity

The fourth book of Virgil's *Georgics* closes with the myth of Aristaeus, the beekeeper whose bees have died. Instructed through Proteus that his loss is punishment for the death of Eurydice, who fled from him and was bitten by a serpent, he sacrifices bulls and heifers, and from their rotting carcasses swarms of bees arise (Virgil, *Georgics* 4.281–314, 4.548–558). The ancient technique of generating bees from a slaughtered ox was called *bugonia*. Samson's riddle belongs to the same imaginary: out of the eater came forth meat, and out of the strong came forth sweetness, the honeycomb found in the carcass of a lion (Judges 14:8–14).

Bugonia names its protagonist's trade. Teddy is a beekeeper who watches his colonies collapse and who, like Aristaeus, performs a sacrifice to restore the order he believes has been violated. But the victim of the film's sacrifice is not an ox, and not finally the captive executive; it is the species. The corpus's arc can now be stated. At the Bouphonia the ox was killed, guilt was displaced onto the knife, and

the victim was stuffed and restored to the plough in a comedy of innocence. At the *bugonia* the ox is killed and not restored; new life is generated from its corruption, and that life is not its own. Between the two lies the trajectory of the corpus: from the displacement of guilt to the replacement of the victim, from a sacrifice that pretends to preserve its object to a sacrifice that is fertile only because its object is gone. In *Bugonia* humanity is the ox.

V

Chapter Five

Beast, Human, God

The Anthropological Machine and the Lanthimosian Bestiary

5.1 Aristotle's Partition
5.2 The Dog
5.3 The Deer, the Goat, the Rabbit
5.4 The Lobster and the Bee
5.5 The Cat and the Chimeras
5.6 Gods and Their Machines

5.1 Aristotle's Partition

The *Politics* defines the human being as a political animal in a greater degree than any bee or any gregarious animal, because the human alone possesses *logos*, speech that declares the just and the unjust; whoever cannot live in a polis, or needs nothing because he is sufficient to himself, is either a beast or a god (*Politics* 1253a). The Lanthimosian corpus is a sustained interrogation of this partition. Its humans are continually demoted to beasts, promoted to gods, or exposed as neither; and the one creature Aristotle named as a lesser political animal, the bee, is the creature with which the corpus ends.

Agamben (2002) called the apparatus that produces the human by separating it from the animal the anthropological machine. In its ancient form the machine humanizes the animal (the slave, the barbarian, the foreigner as animals in human form); in its modern form it animalizes the human (the ape-man, the comatose patient, the inhabitant of the camp). Both versions operate by an inclusive exclusion: the animal is captured within the human as its inner frontier. Lanthimos builds the machine literally. The Hotel of *The Lobster* converts humans who fail its test into animals of their choosing; *Poor Things* converts a man into a creature with a goat's brain; *Dogtooth* teaches children to bark. The machine is not a metaphor for power; it is the power.

Heidegger's lecture course of 1929–30 (Heidegger 1983) proposed three theses: the stone is worldless, the animal is poor in world (*weltarm*), and the human is world-forming. The title that Alasdair Gray chose and Lanthimos retained, *Poor Things*, resonates, whatever its intended reference, with Heidegger's middle term. The film's creatures — Bella, the chimeras in Godwin's yard, eventually General Blessington — are poor in world, and the film is the story of one of them becoming world-forming. Uexküll's (1934) *Umwelt*, the environment of meaning-carriers proper to each organism, describes the world of *Dogtooth* exactly: a garden-sized environment in which airplanes are toys, cats are predators, and the sea is a chair — an *Umwelt* designed by a father.

5.2 The Dog

The Greek title of *Dogtooth*, *Kynodontas*, names the canine tooth; the same root gives *kynikos*, dog-like, the name of the Cynic philosophers. The dog is the corpus's first animal and its most philosophical one. In *Dogtooth* the father's visits to a dog trainer set the education of the family's dog and that of his children in explicit parallel, and the children learn to bark on all fours to repel cats. In *The Lobster* David's companion is his brother, transformed into a dog after failing the Hotel's test; the brother's killing by the Heartless Woman is the film's pivot. In *Kinds of Kindness* a vision is recounted of a world in which dogs govern and humans are their domestic animals, an inversion that Swift had already imagined in the rational horses and bestial Yahoos of *Gulliver's Travels* (Swift 1726) and that Tolstoy used in "Kholstomer" (Tolstoy 1886), the story told by a horse, which Shklovsky (1917) made the paradigm of estrangement.

Haraway (2003) proposed the companion species as a relation of significant otherness, co-constituted through histories of training. The Lanthimosian dog is the reverse: an image of insignificant sameness, the creature into which a human can be turned by rule and whose obedience is the model for human obedience. The dog is also, however, the Cynic's emblem. Diogenes, called the dog, answered Plato's definition of the human as a featherless biped by plucking a chicken and presenting it as Plato's man (Diogenes Laertius 6.40). The Cynic dog stands for shamelessness as a philosophical practice, and Chapter Eight will argue that Bella Baxter is the corpus's only Cynic.

5.3 The Deer, the Goat, the Rabbit

The deer is Artemis's animal, and its killing opens the Atreid catastrophe that *Sacred Deer* restages. Ovid adds a second myth: Actaeon, the hunter who saw Artemis bathing, was transformed into a stag and torn apart by his own hounds (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 3.138–252). The punishment for seeing is to become the hunted; Chapter Seven will return to the eye.

The goat is the animal of the title and of the argument. *Tragōidia* may mean the song of the goat, or the song at the goat's sacrifice (Burkert 1966). In Leviticus 16 one goat is sacrificed and another, the scapegoat, is sent into the wilderness bearing the community's sins. The satyrs of the satyr play, with which the tragic tetralogy ended, were goat-men, the chorus of the remainder. In the closing garden of *Poor Things* a man with a goat's brain grazes on the lawn; in the silent short *Bleat* (2022) the goat's cry gives the film its name. The goat is the animal that remains.

The rabbit belongs to *The Favourite*. Anne's seventeen rabbits are the living memorials of her dead children, substitutes that eat, breed, and must be fed. Ngai (2012) has shown that the aesthetic category of the cute, elicited by the small, soft, and helpless, contains its own aggression: the cute object invites squeezing as well as tenderness. Abigail's foot on a rabbit is the cute's aggression made explicit. Psychoanalysis supplies the rest. The child of Freud's (1920) *fort-da* game masters his mother's absence by throwing a spool away and pulling it back; Winnicott (1953) described the transitional object that stands between the infant and the world; Abraham and Torok (1978) described the crypt, the unmourned object incorporated whole and kept alive in secret. Anne's rabbit room is a crypt made of fur.

5.4 The Lobster and the Bee

David chooses to become a lobster, should he fail, because lobsters live for more than a hundred years, have blue blood like aristocrats, and remain fertile all their lives. The choice is the Hotel's ideology in exoskeleton: longevity, rank, and reproduction, the values of the couple transposed to the solitary animal. Deleuze and Guattari (1980), in their plateau on the geology of morals, have Professor Challenger declare that “God is a Lobster, or a double pincer, a double bind,” and describe every stratum as doubly articulated. *The Lobster* is organized by exactly

such a double articulation. The Hotel and the Woods are the two pincers of a single claw, a compulsory coupling and a compulsory solitude that grip the subject between them; the double bind is the film's political form.

The bee is the corpus's final animal. Aristotle's comparison between the bee and the political animal recurs in Mandeville's *Fable of the Bees* (Mandeville 1714), in which private vices yield public benefits, and in Maeterlinck's (1901) spirit of the hive, the collective intelligence that no individual bee possesses. In *Bugonia* Teddy tends his hives and grieves the collapse of his colonies; by the end humanity has been removed and the hive remains, the lesser political animal outliving the one that claimed to be more political than any bee.

5.5 The Cat and the Chimeras

The cat that strays into the garden of *Dogtooth* is killed with shears. Derrida (2006) began his late meditation on the animal with the gaze of his cat, seeing him naked in the bathroom: the animal as the one who looks back, and before whom the human first feels shame. In *Dogtooth* the only animal to look into the enclosure from outside is killed, and its gaze is converted into a myth of predation. The immunitary reflex of Chapter Two here takes animal form: the sphere kills the witness.

Poor Things populates Godwin's household with chimeras, hybrid creatures assembled from the parts of different species. The tradition is literary before it is cinematic. In Wells's *The Island of Doctor Moreau* (Wells 1896) vivisected animals recite a Law whose refrain asks whether they are not men; in Bulgakov's *Heart of a Dog* (Bulgakov 1987) a stray dog given human glands becomes a boorish citizen. The goat-brained general of *Poor Things* reverses Bulgakov's experiment. A man who wished to mutilate a woman is reduced to an animal's docility, and the film presents the result as justice. The anthropological machine is operated, for once, by its former material.

5.6 Gods and Their Machines

If the corpus demotes humans to beasts, it also produces gods. Godwin Baxter, whom Bella calls “God,” is a creator scarred by his own father's experiments, a deity who is himself a product of the laboratory. Martin in *Sacred Deer* is a god of the Euripidean kind: like Dionysus in the *Bacchae*, he enters a household as an unrecognized stranger, demands acknowledgment, and destroys the house through its own members; like the visitor of Pasolini's *Teorema* (1968), he undoes a bourgeois family by entering it. The Hotel Manager of *The Lobster* is a bureaucratic deity whose own marriage the loners expose as hollow. Queen Anne is the sovereign of *The Favourite*, and Kantorowicz's (1957) doctrine of the king's two bodies — the mortal natural body and the immortal body politic — is inverted in her: the film shows almost exclusively the natural body, gouty, grieving, and sick, while the body politic flickers at the margins in the form of a war conducted elsewhere. Raymond and Omi in *Kinds of Kindness*, both played by Willem Dafoe, are patron-gods whose will defines the good. Michelle in *Bugonia* is a goddess in

the form of an executive.

Plato's *Protagoras* (320c–322d) supplies the myth that orders these figures. Epimetheus distributed all the capacities among the animals and left humans naked; Prometheus stole fire and technical skill for them; and Zeus, seeing that they destroyed one another for want of political art, sent Hermes to distribute *aidōs* (shame, respect) and *dikē* (justice) among all. Stiegler (1994) read the myth as the account of an originary default: the human is the animal without qualities, constituted by prosthesis. The Lanthimosian human is the creature to whom *aidōs* and *dikē* have not been distributed, and for whom rules must be manufactured as prostheses. The shamelessness of the corpus — its characters' candor about sex, pain, and desire — is the absence of *aidōs*; its rigid rules are the prosthetic replacement of *dikē*. Martin's "justice" is *dikē* as a prosthetic limb, attached by force. The gods of the corpus are not the donors of these virtues but their counterfeiters.

VI

Chapter Six

Kinship Trouble

Incest Machines, Performed Families, and the Contract

6.1 The Incest Machine
6.2 Performed Kinship: Alps
6.3 Compulsory Coupledom: The Lobster
6.4 The Court: Triangular Desire and the Servant
6.5 Institution and Contract
6.6 The Euthyphro of Kindness

6.1 The Incest Machine

Lévi-Strauss (1949) located the threshold between nature and culture in the prohibition of incest, a rule universal like nature and variable like culture; its positive face is exogamy, the exchange of women between groups, through which alliance is founded. *Dogtooth* stages this theory as a domestic experiment. The father imports Christina from his workplace to satisfy his son's sexual needs and pays her in cash: exogamy is replaced by a wage, alliance by a service contract. When the father discovers the videocassettes Christina has bartered into the house, he beats the elder daughter with one of them and goes to Christina's flat to strike her with her own VCR; she is not readmitted, and the family must satisfy the son internally. The parents decide that the son will choose one of his sisters as his new sexual partner, and the elder daughter is made to have sex with her brother. The incest that follows is not a transgression of the family's law but its logical completion: the autoimmune endogamy of a sphere that has expelled its last contact with the outside.

Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (Freud 1913) imagined the primal father who monopolized the women of the horde until his sons killed him and instituted the prohibition. The father of *Dogtooth* is not this figure. He does not monopolize; he allocates. Deleuze and Guattari (1972) argued that the Oedipal family is not a natural structure but a territorializing machine that captures desire and codes it; the Lanthimosian family is such a machine without the Oedipal alibi, an engineering project in which desire is routed, rationed, and redirected according to a stipulated plan.

The invented brother completes the apparatus. The children are told that a brother lives beyond the fence; when the father needs a lesson in the dangers of the outside, the brother is declared killed by a cat. Albee's *Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?* (Albee 1962) turns on an imaginary son, the private fiction of a marriage, whom George "kills" when Martha violates the rules of their game. In both cases the imaginary child is the family's most sacred possession and its most available sacrifice: a victim who can be killed because he never existed, and whose death disciplines the living.

6.2 Performed Kinship: Alps

Butler (2000), reading Antigone, argued that kinship is not a structure given by blood but a practice sustained by repeated performance, whose norms can be contested by those who perform them otherwise. *Alps* makes kinship a performance for hire. Its members play the dead daughter, the dead wife, the dead son, reciting phrases supplied by the bereaved and correcting their performances on instruction. Sartre's (1943) waiter, who plays at being a waiter with excessive precision, exemplifies bad faith: the attempt to coincide with a role as a thing coincides with its essence. The members of Alps are professionals of bad faith, and the nurse's crisis is the discovery that bad faith, practiced with sufficient devotion, is indistinguishable from love.

Baudrillard (1981) described the simulacrum as the copy that precedes and replaces its original; in *Alps* the substitute does not imitate the dead so much as outlive them, and the parents' grief is administered by the copy. Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (Kierkegaard 1843b) recounts Constantin Constantius's attempt to repeat a journey to Berlin and his discovery that repetition is impossible in the domain of experience; *Alps* is a business predicated on the possibility of repetition, and it fails exactly where Kierkegaard said it would. Freud's (1917) distinction between mourning, which withdraws libido from the lost object, and melancholia, which incorporates the lost object into the ego, clarifies the stakes. The Alps service institutionalizes melancholia: it refuses the withdrawal of libido and supplies a body into which the lost object can be relocated. Later speculative fiction has followed the same path, from the artificial friend trained to continue a sick girl's life in Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun* (Ishiguro 2021) to the android replica of a dead partner in the television episode “Be Right Back” (2013).

6.3 Compulsory Coupledom: The Lobster

Brake (2012) coined *amatonormativity* for the assumption that a central, exclusive, romantic relationship is a universal human goal and should be privileged by law and custom. Rich (1980) had earlier described compulsory heterosexuality as a political institution rather than a natural preference. *The Lobster* is amatonormativity enforced by metamorphosis. On admission, David is asked to declare his sexual orientation; when he asks whether a bisexual option is available, he is told that it has been discontinued for operational reasons. Sexual identity is not repressed but administered — an entry on a form, subject to the logistics of the institution.

Foucault (1976) argued against the repressive hypothesis that modern power incites sexuality rather than silencing it, multiplying discourses and producing desire as an object of management. The Hotel's regime is the refutation of the repressive hypothesis in miniature. Masturbation is forbidden, and the Lisping Man's hand is forced into a hot toaster as punishment, yet a chambermaid is required to sexually stimulate the male guests without release; desire is produced as pressure in order to drive the subject toward the only sanctioned outlet. The Hotel's didactic skits, in which the solitary are shown choking and set upon by a would-be rapist, belong to the same pedagogy of incitement.

The loners' raid on the Hotel exposes the couple at the summit of the institution. The loners' leader forces the Manager's husband to choose between his wife's life and his own, handing him a pistol; he shoots her, and the pistol is empty. The demonstration is exact: the model couple, tested at the limit, is revealed as two monads each willing to sacrifice the other. Berlant (2011) called cruel optimism the attachment to a fantasy that obstructs the flourishing it promises; the couple is the corpus's paradigm of cruel optimism, and David's final gesture — the knife raised to his eye to match his blinded partner — is its consummation. Love, under amatonormativity, is the symmetry of damage.

6.4 The Court: Triangular Desire and the Servant

Elias (1969) described the court society as a figuration in which etiquette is an instrument of power and every gesture is a move in a game of rank. *The Favourite* stages court society as a closed triangle. Sarah Churchill, Duchess of Marlborough, and her impoverished cousin Abigail Hill compete for the Queen's bed and therefore for her power: Sarah is Anne's lover when the film begins, and Abigail displaces her by becoming Anne's lover in turn. Girard (1961) described desire as triangular: the subject desires an object because a rival, the mediator, desires it. In *The Favourite* the object is the Queen and the mediation is mutual; each woman's desire is authenticated by the other's. Sedgwick (1985) analyzed the erotic triangle in which two men's rivalry for a woman conceals a bond between the men; *The Favourite* reconfigures the triangle among women and makes its currency explicitly sexual and political: access to the Queen's body is access to policy.

The servant-master dialectic sharpens the triangle. Genet's *The Maids* (Genet 1947), in which two servants rehearse the murder of their mistress by playing her, and Losey's *The Servant* (1963), from Harold Pinter's screenplay, in which a manservant gradually reverses the hierarchy of the household, are the film's closest theatrical and cinematic kin. Hegel's (1807) dialectic of lordship and bondage holds that the bondsman, through fear and labor, attains a self-consciousness the lord cannot reach. Abigail ascends through service — a poultice for the Queen's gout, attendance in the bedchamber, the tending of the rabbits — and supplants her rival. But the film's last image returns her to the posture of service: kneeling, massaging the Queen's leg, her hair gripped in the Queen's hand. The dialectic does not complete; it loops. Sartre's *No Exit* (Sartre 1944), in which three people discover that hell is other people, supplies the final template: a closed room, three occupants, no exit, the gaze as punishment.

6.5 Institution and Contract

Deleuze's study of Masoch (Deleuze 1967) distinguished sadism from masochism not as complementary perversions but as incommensurable forms. Sadism operates through institution: impersonal law, demonstration, the apathy of the libertine who reasons as he tortures. Masochism operates through contract: the victim educates the torturer, persuades her, and binds her by a written agreement to the role he has scripted. The Lanthimosian enclosures belong at first sight to the Sadean type. The household of *Dogtooth* and the Hotel of *The Lobster* are institutions whose rules exceed the will of any participant, and their violence is administered with apathy. Sade's *Juliette* and the regulations of the libertines in *The 120 Days of Sodom*, filmed by Pasolini as *Salò* (1975), are the ancestors of the Hotel's code. Lacan (1963) argued that the Sadean maxim reveals the truth of the Kantian categorical imperative, a universal law indifferent to the pathology of the subject who must obey it; Horkheimer and Adorno (1947) read *Juliette* as the endpoint of an enlightenment whose reason has become pure calculation, indifferent to ends. The Lanthimosian rule is Sadean in exactly this sense: formal,

universal, and indifferent to the bodies it governs.

Yet the first story of *Kinds of Kindness* belongs to the Masochian type. Robert's servitude to Raymond is contractual in spirit: he has consented to it, it rewards him, and its terms are specified with bureaucratic care. What the film discovers is the intermediate form that joins the two, the *contractual institution*, in which the subject consents to an order that then operates with the impersonality of law. It is the form of the modern employment relation, of the sect, and of marriage understood as a jurisdiction; and it is the form of the corpus's households.

6.6 The Euthyphro of Kindness

The title *Kinds of Kindness* contains a pun that Hamlet made in his first line — "a little more than kin, and less than kind" (*Hamlet* 1.2.65) — binding kin, kind as species, and kindness as disposition. The film's question is Euthyphro's. Socrates asked whether the pious is loved by the gods because it is pious, or is pious because it is loved by the gods (*Euthyphro* 10a). The medieval voluntarism associated with Ockham answered that the good is good because God wills it, and that God could in principle command what we call evil. In the first story of *Kinds of Kindness*, kindness is whatever Raymond wills; Robert's return to Raymond's favor restores kindness as the name of submission. In the third, purity is whatever the sect's leaders declare it to be. When Emily's estranged husband Joseph drugs her and rapes her while she is unconscious, the sect does not treat her as the victim of a crime: it declares her "contaminated" and expels her. Purity so defined is a property that another person's crime can remove, and the stipulation converts the injured party into the guilty one: the comedy of innocence run in reverse, with guilt displaced not onto the knife but onto the victim. The kinds of kindness are the kinds decreed by a nomothete. Kinship, in the corpus, is not a bond given by nature but a jurisdiction administered by a sovereign of definitions, which returns this chapter to the lexicon from which the dissertation began.

VII

Chapter Seven

An-aesthetics

Deadpan, Cruelty, and the Dancing Remainder

7.1 The Anesthetized Heart
7.2 Cruelty as Rigor
7.3 Lens, Frame, and the Face
7.4 Sound
7.5 The Eye and the Punishment of Theoria
7.6 Dance as the Dionysian Remainder

7.1 The Anesthetized Heart

Bergson (1900) defined the comic as something mechanical encrusted on the living, and observed that laughter requires a momentary anesthesia of the heart: we laugh at what we have ceased, for a moment, to feel with. The Lanthimosian corpus makes this anesthesia both theme and method. In *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* Steven and Anna make love in a game they call "general anesthesia," in which she lies motionless as a patient on the table. *Poor Things* returns obsessively to the operating theater. In *Bugonia* Teddy chemically castrates himself with hormone injections before the abduction and persuades his reluctant cousin Don to do the same, so that their captive cannot seduce them; the corpus here anesthetizes desire itself, offering a bodily capacity to the rule in the manner of the self-castrating devotees of Cybele in Catullus' *Attis* poem (Catullus 63). Throughout the corpus, performers speak as though under sedation. Bergson's condition of the comic has become the condition of the characters, and the spectator is left to feel what the characters do not.

Buck-Morss (1992), rereading Benjamin, argued that modernity transformed aesthetics, originally the discourse of sensory perception, into anaesthetics, a technology for numbing the sensorium against the shocks of industrial life. The Lanthimosian style is an *an-aesthetics* in a double sense. It withdraws affect from the performance and thereby displaces it onto the viewer; the numbed character produces the sensitized spectator. The deadpan is not an absence of affect but its transfer. This dissertation has called the deadpan the affect of deduction: the tone of a mind following a premise to its conclusion without admitting any consideration the premise has not licensed. The characters' flatness is the sound of their fidelity.

7.2 Cruelty as Rigor

Artaud (1938) insisted that the theater of cruelty did not mean bloodshed but rigor: implacable intention, decision, a necessity to which the actor submits as the body submits to fate. Lanthimos is Artaudian in this strict sense and anti-Artaudian in every other. Artaud wanted performers who would signal as though through flames, bodies convulsed by metaphysical intensity; Lanthimos's performers signal through nothing, bodies held rigidly still while the rule works upon them. The cruelty lies not in the scream but in the protocol.

Brecht's *Short Organum* (Brecht 1949) theorized the estrangement effect as a technique for making the familiar strange, blocking the spectator's identification in order to provoke judgment. The Lanthimosian flatness estranges, but without Brecht's didactic end: it does not expose the historical contingency of social relations so that they may be changed, but exposes the contingency of rules in order to watch them bind anyway. Bresson (1975) called his non-professional performers models and required them to repeat gestures until every intention had been drained from them, so that they revealed what they did not know they possessed. The Lanthimosian performer is a professional actor asked to become a

Bressonian model, and the tension between skill and its suppression produces the characteristic effect. Ngai (2005) named stuplimity the mixture of astonishment and boredom produced by repetitive, agglutinative works; the corpus's long rituals — endurance games, rehearsals, reenactments — produce exactly this compound. Deleuze (1985) distinguished in modern cinema the everyday body from the ceremonial body, the body made to pass through postures and attitudes as through a rite. Lanthimos's bodies are ceremonial even when they are eating breakfast.

7.3 Lens, Frame, and the Face

The later films are photographed with extreme wide-angle and fisheye lenses, most conspicuously *The Favourite* and *Poor Things*. The fisheye is the optics of the sphere. It curves the rectilinear world into a globe, so that the frame appears as a bubble whose edges bend around the viewer. What the Athenian films achieved through architecture — the fence, the pool, the hotel corridor — the later films achieve through optics: the image itself becomes an enclosure.

The early films operate by subtraction. *Dogtooth* repeatedly frames its characters so that their heads are cut off by the upper edge of the image, leaving torsos in conversation. Levinas (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face of the other, whose nakedness commands before any consent: thou shalt not kill. The decapitating frame of *Dogtooth* is an ethical proposition. It shows a world in which bodies are present but faces are withheld, and in which, accordingly, the prohibition the face pronounces never sounds. The camera's refusal of the face is the formal correlate of the father's regime.

The tracking shots down the hospital corridors of *Sacred Deer* recall Kubrick, whose symmetrical compositions and slow, predatory camera movements in *The Shining* (1980) construct an institutional space that seems to watch its inhabitants. The film's high overhead shots adopt the view of a god or an experimenter. Roy Andersson's tableaux, with their static frames and pallid performers, suggest a Nordic cousin of the Lanthimosian deadpan, though Andersson's tone is elegiac where Lanthimos's is forensic.

7.4 Sound

The Killing of a Sacred Deer opens on a heart beating in an opened chest, accompanied by the opening chorus of Bach's *St John Passion*. The sacrificial matrix of the film is announced in its first image and its first sound: the Passion of the Lamb over the opened body. The score's alternation of sacred repertory with the dissonant modernism of composers such as Ligeti sets two temporalities against each other, the liturgical time of sacrifice and the clinical time of the procedure. *The Favourite* interleaves baroque repertory with modernist and minimalist pieces, so that the court's music keeps modulating into a timeless drone. Jerskin Fendrix's scores, most conspicuously for *Poor Things*, favor detuned, childlike timbres, instruments played as though by someone still learning them, and they give the corpus its most audible figure of the remainder: sound that

exceeds the competence it seems to require.

7.5 The Eye and the Punishment of Theoria

The corpus returns to the eye with a persistence that constitutes an argument. In *Sacred Deer* the third stage of Martin's curse is bleeding from the eyes, and the executioner blinds himself with a woolen cap before firing. In *The Lobster* the loners' leader has the Short Sighted Woman blinded, and David raises a knife to his own eye. In *Dogtooth* Christina is blindfolded on her journeys to and from the villa so that she cannot know where it is. The lineage is dense: the razor slicing an eye in Buñuel and Dalí's *Un Chien Andalou* (1929); Bataille's *Story of the Eye* (Bataille 1928) and his entry on the eye in *Documents* (Bataille 1929); Oedipus's self-blinding; Hoffmann's "The Sandman" (Hoffmann 1816), in which Freud (1919) found the fear of losing one's eyes to be a substitute for the fear of castration; the Ludovico treatment of Kubrick's A *Clockwork Orange* (1971), in which the eyes are held open by force; Saramago's *Blindness* (Saramago 1995), in which a society is quarantined by a contagion of sightlessness.

The Greek word for spectatorship, *theōria*, originally named the sending of an observer to a religious festival: to watch was a sacred function. The myth of Actaeon records its punishment. He who sees what he should not is transformed into the object of the hunt. The Lanthimosian eye is the organ of *theōria* punished; within the films, those who see are blinded or bleed. The spectator is spared. Our eyes remain open, and the films' refusal to punish us is the most unsettling of their cruelties, since it leaves us in the position of the experimenter.

7.6 Dance as the Dionysian Remainder

Nietzsche (1872) derived tragedy from the tension between the Apollonian, the principle of form and individuation, and the Dionysian, the rapture in which the individual dissolves. The Lanthimosian rule is Apollonian to the point of parody: measured, bounded, individuating. And it is periodically ruptured by dance. In *Dogtooth* the daughters perform a routine for their parents' anniversary, and the elder daughter's contribution, a convulsive citation of *Flashdance*, breaks the domestic ceremony apart. In *Alps* the gymnast, whose coach forbids her to perform to popular music until he judges her ready, insists on the music she prefers, and her routine becomes the film's figure of desire exceeding discipline. In *The Lobster* the loners dance alone in the woods, each wearing headphones, each moving to a private rhythm in a silent collective. *The Favourite* stages an anachronistic court dance whose angular, improvised-looking movements drive the Queen from the room. *Poor Things* gives Bella a dance in a Lisbon restaurant, a sequence of lurches and leaps whose ungainliness is its freedom. In *Kinds of Kindness* Emily dances, alone and ecstatic, in a parking lot.

Durkheim (1912) described collective effervescence as the state in which assembled individuals are carried beyond themselves and the sacred is born. The Lanthimosian dance is effervescence without collectivity: solitary, uncoordinated, embarrassing, the negative image of the mass choreographies that Lanthimos

helped design for the Olympic ceremonies of 2004. It is the body exceeding the rule without founding a new community, the remainder in motion. It is also the goat. Tragedy, in Aristotle's account, grew out of the leaders of the dithyramb, the choral song and dance of Dionysus (*Poetics* 1449a), and the satyrs who closed the tragic tetralogy danced as goat-men. When a Lanthimos character dances, the goat song resumes for a moment inside the laboratory.

VIII

Chapter Eight

The Kynic Exception

Poor Things and the Experiment That Experiments

8.1 The Anti-Dogtooth
8.2 Kynicism against Cynicism
8.3 Candide in Reverse
8.4 The Created Woman
8.5 The Surgeon's Knife
8.6 Critiques and Limits

8.1 The Anti-Dogtooth

Poor Things is *Dogtooth* run backwards. Both begin with a creature confined to a house by a patriarchal scientist of the household, taught a curated language, and forbidden the outside. *Dogtooth* ends with its creature in the trunk of the sovereign's car; *Poor Things* sends its creature out into the world and returns her as a surgeon. The film is the corpus's one sustained narrative of emancipation, and this chapter must decide whether it refutes the argument of the preceding chapters or confirms it.

Gray's novel (Gray 1992) presents Bella's story through a nested apparatus: the memoir of her husband Archibald McCandless, which recounts the resurrection, and a letter by Victoria McCandless that dismisses the memoir as fantasy and gives a sober, realist account of her life. The novel is thus a postmodern contest of narratives in which the fantastic is framed by skepticism. The film discards the frame. It believes Bella, and in believing her it gives the corpus its only protagonist whose freedom is not immediately reabsorbed by a rule. Arendt (1958) called natality the human capacity to begin, the fact that each birth introduces into the world something unprecedented. Bella is natality in adult form, born into a grown body and beginning everything at once.

8.2 Kynicism against Cynicism

The Cynics of antiquity, whose name recalls the dog, practiced philosophy as a way of life lived in public and without shame. Diogenes ate, slept, and satisfied his needs in the agora, and answered the conventions of the polis by violating them. Foucault's final lectures (Foucault 2009) read Cynicism as the most radical form of *parrhēsia*, truth-telling that exposes the life of the truth-teller, a philosophy that scandalizes by its very existence. Sloterdijk (1983) distinguished kynicism — plebeian, bodily, cheeky, the dog's laughter against idealist pomposity — from cynicism, the enlightened false consciousness of the powerful, who know that their ideals are hollow and serve them anyway.

Bella is a kynic. She spits out food she dislikes, announces her sexual discoveries at table, and asks the questions polite society suppresses; her shamelessness is not transgression for its own sake but an epistemology, a refusal to pretend not to know. Harry Astley, the passenger who takes her education in hand aboard the ship, is a cynic. He shows her the dying children of Alexandria in order to break her optimism, teaching that the world is cruel and that the wise accommodate themselves to it. Bella's response is characteristic of the kynic: she gives away her companion's winnings in an attempt to relieve the suffering she has seen. The gift is naive and ineffective — it never reaches its intended recipients — but it is the gesture of a creature who has not yet learned that knowledge excuses inaction. The cynic knows and does nothing; the kynic knows and acts, badly.

8.3 Candide in Reverse

The film's structure is the conte philosophique's. Voltaire's *Candide* (Voltaire 1759) sends its naive hero from a sheltered castle through the catastrophes of the world, including the Lisbon earthquake of 1755, accompanied by the optimist Pangloss and later the pessimist Martin, and concludes that one must cultivate one's garden. Bella, too, begins in a sheltered house, passes through Lisbon, is tutored by optimists and pessimists, and ends in a garden. The Buddhist legend supplies a second template. The prince Siddhartha, confined in his father's palace, encounters on his first excursions old age, sickness, death, and an ascetic, and renounces the palace. Bella's Alexandria is her first sight of death.

The garden, however, is where the argument of the corpus reasserts itself. The final scene gathers Bella, her husband Max, her friend Toinette, Felicity (Godwin's second experiment), and General Alfie Blessington — the husband whose cruelty Victoria had drowned herself to escape, and who, reclaiming her, planned to have her clitoris surgically removed — who now, with the brain of a goat, grazes on the lawn. Voltaire's garden was cultivated by labor; Bella's is grazed by a sacrifice. The emancipation of the created woman culminates in the creation of a new creature, and the experimental relation is not abolished but inverted. Here the first corollary of the Goat Theorem is anticipated: emancipation that does not exit the sphere through the remainder reinstitutes sacrifice. The goat is on the lawn.

8.4 The Created Woman

The film enters a long tradition of created women. Hesiod's Pandora, fashioned by the gods as a *kalon kakon*, a beautiful evil (*Theogony* 585), inaugurates it; Ovid's Pygmalion, whose ivory statue is brought to life by Venus (*Metamorphoses* 10.243–297), perfects the fantasy of the woman as the artist's answer to his own desire; Hoffmann's automaton Olimpia (Hoffmann 1816), Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's Hadaly in *L'Ève future* (Villiers 1886), the bride of Whale's *Bride of Frankenstein* (1935), and Shaw's Eliza Doolittle in *Pygmalion* (Shaw 1913) extend it through the industrial age. In each case the created woman is her creator's projection: responsive, silent, or programmable. *Poor Things* breaks the tradition by transferring the creator's function to the creature. Bella resolves to become a surgeon, and it is with her own hands, assisted by Max, that she operates on her former husband.

The creator's name invites a further, interpretive resonance. William Godwin married Mary Wollstonecraft, who died in 1797 of complications following the birth of their daughter, the future Mary Shelley, author of *Frankenstein* (Shelley 1818). Godwin Baxter revives a woman who has died pregnant, and the story of the woman he revives becomes, in the film's second half, a demonstration of the education Wollstonecraft demanded in *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (Wollstonecraft 1792) against Rousseau's program for Sophie, the ideal wife trained for pleasing and obedience in the fifth book of *Émile* (Rousseau 1762). Whether or not the resonance was intended, the film can be read as a speculative repair of the

Godwin–Wollstonecraft catastrophe: a woman who died in childbirth returns, and her education is conducted on Wollstonecraft's principles rather than Rousseau's.

8.5 The Surgeon's Knife

Alfie's plan for Bella has a historical referent. The London surgeon Isaac Baker Brown published in 1866 a treatise advocating clitoridectomy as a cure for female nervous disorders, and was expelled from the Obstetrical Society of London in 1867 (Baker Brown 1866). The film's Victorian setting makes the operation a period-accurate threat, and Bella's reversal of it — the would-be mutilator surgically reduced to an animal — is the film's harshest joke. The knife passes from the patriarch's hand to the woman's, but it remains a knife.

The film's premise also inverts a celebrated thought experiment of applied ethics. Thomson (1971) asked her reader to imagine waking to find their circulatory system connected to that of an unconscious violinist whose life depends on it. In *Poor Things* the body of a woman who has chosen death is conscripted, without her consent, to sustain the brain of her unborn child, by a scientist who judges the result worthwhile. The film does not adjudicate the controversies in which Thomson's argument intervened, and neither does this dissertation. It is enough to note that the corpus's one emancipation narrative is built upon a non-consensual substitution: the mother's body given for the child's mind.

8.6 Critiques and Limits

The film has attracted criticism that the argument of this dissertation must register. Mulvey's (1975) account of cinematic looking as structured by a male gaze has been invoked by critics who find that the film's sexual candor reinscribes the spectacle of the female body it claims to liberate. A second objection is sharper. The film presents Bella's mind as developing from infancy, and it shows her beginning a sexual life — first alone, then with Duncan Wedderburn, an adult lawyer who seduces her and takes her abroad — at a stage when it still presents that mind as childlike. Critics argued that this sexualizes a child's mind in an adult's body and invites the audience to enjoy it; defenders replied that her development is accelerated, that the film frames Duncan as a predator whose control she outgrows, and that the scenes depict her agency rather than his. The film's speed does not dissolve the objection, and this dissertation does not pretend that it does. A third objection concerns the Paris brothel in which Bella, penniless, works as a prostitute and receives her political education: critics held that it is rendered with an idealizing lightness that obscures the coercions of sex work.

The present reading does not dissolve these objections; it relocates them. The film is a *reductio in carne* of consent itself, posing the question of who can consent when the capacity for consent is being manufactured in the course of the experiment. The discomfort the film produces is not a flaw external to its argument but part of its remainder, the excess that its emancipatory stipulation cannot absorb. *Poor Things* is the exception that proves the Goat Theorem: even the experiment that frees its subject requires a goat.

IX

Chapter Nine

Genealogies of the Menippea

Lanthimos among the Speculative Philosophers

9.1 The Menippean Form
9.2 Swift and the Modest Proposal
9.3 The Conte Philosophique
9.4 Kafka
9.5 The Dystopian Canon and the Micro-Dystopia
9.6 Cinematic Interlocutors

9.1 The Menippean Form

Bakhtin (1963) reconstructed from antiquity a genre he called the menippea, after Menippus of Gadara, a Cynic of the third century BCE whose works survive only through their influence on Varro, Seneca, and Lucian. Among its characteristics Bakhtin listed a heightened comic element; freedom from the constraints of historical plausibility; the creation of extraordinary situations for the purpose of testing a philosophical idea; the combination of fantasy with a crude slum naturalism; the representation of abnormal moral and psychic states — madness, split personality, unrestrained daydreaming; scandal scenes and violations of decorum; sharp contrasts and oxymoronic combinations; elements of social utopia; the insertion of other genres; and an acute topicality. Frye (1957) called the same form the anatomy, a dissection of intellectual attitudes rather than of characters.

The Lanthimosian corpus satisfies Bakhtin's list with the thoroughness of a textbook case. The testing of an idea in an extraordinary situation is the *reductio in carne* itself; the slum naturalism appears as the corpus's insistence on bodily fluids; abnormal states are the films' dominant psychology; scandal scenes punctuate every film; the social utopias are the Hotel, the sect, the household; the inserted genres include the language primer, the instructional skit, the court entertainment, and the corporate memorandum. Menippus was a Cynic, and the genre he founded is the literary form of Cynic philosophy, the philosophy of the dog. The kynic exception of Chapter Eight is therefore not an exception to the corpus's genre but a return to its origin. Bakhtin (1965) later developed the carnivalesque and the grotesque body — the body that eats, excretes, copulates, and gives birth — as the popular counter-principle to official culture. The Lanthimosian body is grotesque in Bakhtin's sense, but its carnival has been administered: scheduled, like everything else, by the rule.

9.2 Swift and the Modest Proposal

Swift is the corpus's most important literary ancestor. The fourth book of *Gulliver's Travels* (Swift 1726) presents a society of rational horses, the Houyhnhnms, who govern the bestial Yahoos, humans in all but reason; the third book's Academy of Lagado, whose projectors labor to extract sunbeams from cucumbers, is the first satire of experimental science as institutional folly. A *Modest Proposal* (Swift 1729) is the paradigmatic *reductio in carne*. Its projector, reasoning from the premises of political arithmetic, proposes with perfect composure that the infants of the Irish poor be sold as food for the rich, and supplies suggestions for their preparation. The satire works by accepting the premise that human beings are commodities and following it, calmly, to the dinner table. Anna Murphy's calculation in *Sacred Deer*, the Thyestean thumb of *Kinds of Kindness*, and the whole economy of the Hotel belong to the family of the modest proposal. Swift's projector and Lanthimos's characters share a tone, and the tone is the argument: the more reasonable the voice, the more monstrous the

conclusion.

9.3 The Conte Philosophique

The eighteenth-century conte philosophique refined the Menippean experiment into a narrative of estrangement. Montesquieu's *Persian Letters* (Montesquieu 1721) regarded France through the eyes of visitors to whom its customs were arbitrary; Voltaire's *Micromégas* (Voltaire 1752) sent a giant from Sirius to question terrestrial philosophers, and ended with the gift of a book of philosophy whose pages turn out to be blank; *L'Ingénu* (Voltaire 1767) sent a Huron through French institutions. The naive observer is the conte's instrument: the foreigner, the child, the savage, the visitor from another world, to whom convention appears as convention. Shklovsky (1917) later named the procedure *ostranenie*. The Lanthimosian corpus retains the procedure while inverting its perspective. Its naive observers — the children of *Dogtooth*, the guests of the Hotel, Bella — do not see through conventions; they are produced by them. Estrangement is no longer the observer's privilege but the spectator's: we are the Persians, the Huron, the Sirian, visiting a world whose rules we cannot share.

9.4 Kafka

Kafka supplies the corpus's model of law without content. In *The Trial* (Kafka 1925) Josef K. is arrested without being told his crime and destroyed by a court whose law he never sees; in the parable "Before the Law" (Kafka 1915a) a man waits all his life at a door meant only for him, which is shut at his death. In *The Metamorphosis* (Kafka 1915b) a traveling salesman wakes as an insect, and his family, after a period of disgust, adapts, as the families of *Nimic* and *Kinds of Kindness* adapt to their substitutes. Max Brod (1937) reported that Kafka laughed so hard while reading the first chapter of *The Trial* to his friends that he could hardly go on, and the anecdote has become the standard warning against reading Kafka solemnly. The same warning applies to Lanthimos. The deadpan in both is not gravity but a comic procedure that declines to announce itself.

Deleuze and Guattari (1975) read Kafka's becomings-animal as lines of flight, escapes from the Oedipal family and the bureaucratic machine. The Lanthimosian becoming-animal reverses the vector. In *The Lobster* it is not an escape but a sentence, administered by the institution to those who fail its test; in *Dogtooth* the children bark on command. Only in the last film does becoming-animal regain something of Kafka's ambiguity: the bees of *Bugonia* are not a punishment but a succession.

9.5 The Dystopian Canon and the Micro-Dystopia

The twentieth-century dystopia supplied the corpus with its institutions. Zamyatin's *We* (Zamyatin 1924) rationed sexual contact through pink tickets, synchronized life by the Table of Hours, and ended with the Great Operation, which excised the imagination. Huxley's *Brave New World* (Huxley 1932) conditioned infants by electric shock to fear books and flowers, a conditioning

whose domestic descendant is the definition, in *Dogtooth*, of a small yellow flower as a zombie. Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (Orwell 1949) imagined Newspeak, a language designed to make heterodox thought impossible by reducing vocabulary, and Room 101, in which each prisoner confronts the worst thing in the world, tailored to his fears. Lanthimos borrows the logic of all three while abandoning their scale. His dystopias are micro-dystopias, totalitarian orders miniaturized to the size of a household, a hotel, or a sect, and run without a state. The dystopia has been privatized.

Later speculative fiction offers closer kin. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (Le Guin 1973), developed from William James's (1891) image of a utopia whose happiness depends on the torment of a single lost soul, poses the calculus of *Sacred Deer*: the flourishing of many purchased by the suffering of one. Jackson's "The Lottery" (Jackson 1948) and Borges's "The Lottery in Babylon" (Borges 1941) show sacrifice by chance as civic ritual. Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (Borges 1940) describes an invented world whose lexicon gradually replaces the real one, the fate of the household of *Dogtooth* in cosmic form. Cortázar's "House Taken Over" (Cortázar 1946) confines two siblings in a house progressively occupied by unnamed presences; Abe's *The Woman in the Dunes* (Abe 1962), filmed by Teshigahara in 1964, traps a man in a sand pit until he ceases to want to leave. Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (Ishiguro 2005) and *The Remains of the Day* (Ishiguro 1989) explore the acceptance of a sacrificial destiny and the self-annihilation of service, the two poles between which Robert of *Kinds of Kindness* oscillates. Ballard's *High-Rise* (Ballard 1975) imagines an enclosed building regressing into tribal violence; Saramago's *Blindness* (1995) quarantines a society stricken by sightlessness; Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (Atwood 1985) builds a state upon the administration of reproduction; Houellebecq's *The Possibility of an Island* (Houellebecq 2005) imagines the replacement of humanity by its clones. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (Dick 1968) devised the Voight-Kampff test, an examination of empathy for distinguishing humans from androids, descended from Turing's (1950) imitation game. *Bugonia* is a Voight-Kampff test administered by a paranoid to a human being in order to prove that she is not one.

9.6 Cinematic Interlocutors

Buñuel is the corpus's cinematic grandfather. *The Exterminating Angel* (1962) traps bourgeois guests in a drawing room by an invisible and unexplained compulsion; *The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie* (1972) frustrates a dinner party without end; *Un Chien Andalou* opens with the eye. Pasolini's *Teorema* (1968) introduces a divine visitor who seduces every member of a bourgeois household and departs, leaving it destroyed; *Medea* (1969) stages archaic sacrifice with anthropological seriousness; *Salò* (1975) films the Sadean institution. Kubrick supplies the conditioning of *A Clockwork Orange* (1971), the candlelit court of *Barry Lyndon* (1975), the institutional labyrinth of *The Shining* (1980), and the ritual of *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999). Haneke is the closest contemporary and the most instructive contrast. *The Seventh Continent* (1989) follows a family that methodically destroys itself; *Funny Games*

(1997) addresses its audience directly to indict its appetite for violence; *The White Ribbon* (2009) anatomizes a punitive pedagogy. Haneke's cinema is moral pedagogy: it indicts the spectator. Lanthimos's is amoral demonstration: it shows the spectator a proof and declines to draw the moral. Bresson's *Au hasard Balthazar* (1966), the passion of a donkey among humans, is the model for a cinema in which the animal is the only innocent.

The Greek tradition supplies Cacoyannis's *Iphigenia* (1977), the tragic source filmed as national epic, and Angelopoulos's *The Travelling Players* (1975), which maps the Atreid myth onto modern Greek history. Losey's *The Servant* anticipates *The Favourite*. Kaufman's *Synecdoche, New York* (2008) builds an infinite recursion of substitutes, and *Anomalisa* (2015, co-directed with Duke Johnson) sets its action in a hotel named Fregoli, after the delusion in which different people are believed to be a single persecutor — the mirror image of the Capgras delusion that governs the second story of *Kinds of Kindness*. Östlund's *Triangle of Sadness* (2022) and Andersson's *Songs from the Second Floor* (2000) belong to the same continental deadpan. Jang Joon-hwan's *Save the Green Planet!* (2003), the source of *Bugonia*, combined kidnapping thriller, science fiction, and slapstick in a register that Lanthimos's adaptation cools to his own temperature.

The Greek Weird Wave itself is best understood as a collective menippea. Athina Rachel Tsangari's *Attenberg* (2010), in which Lanthimos appears as an actor, follows a young woman learning intimacy through nature documentaries; her *Chevalier* (2015) confines six men on a yacht competing in an endless contest to determine who is the best in general. Babis Makridis's *Pity* (2018), co-written by Filippou, follows a man addicted to the sympathy that grief elicits. Fisher (2016) distinguished the weird, that which does not belong, from the eerie, a failure of absence or of presence. The rules of the Weird Wave are weird in Fisher's sense, intrusions of an alien order into the familiar; its endings are eerie, agency withdrawn from scenes that still seem to require it.



Chapter Ten

The Paranoid Apocalypse

Bugonia and the End of the Experiment

10.1 The Basement
10.2 The Underground Man
10.3 Cynical Reason in the Executive Suite
10.4 Inverted Theoxeny
10.5 Capitalist Realism and the Eerie
10.6 The Bees

10.1 The Basement

Two basements bracket the late corpus. In *The Killing of a Sacred Deer* Steven binds Martin in the basement of the family home and beats him, hoping to force him to lift the curse; Anna later tends Martin's wounds, kisses his feet, and releases him. Her gesture is the ancient posture of supplication, the suppliant's embrace of the knees and feet of one with the power to spare. In *Bugonia* the basement returns with the positions reversed. Teddy, the avenger, is now the captor, and the one restrained in the basement is the executive he holds responsible for the world's ruin. The two films are further linked by a casting rhyme: Alicia Silverstone plays the avenger's mother in both, Martin's widowed mother in the first and Teddy's comatose mother in the second. And both turn on sons avenging parents harmed by medicine. Martin's father died on Steven's operating table; Teddy's mother lies in a coma after taking part in a clinical trial run by Michelle's company. Teddy's injury begins earlier, with an institution charged with protecting him: Casey, the local deputy who was once his babysitter, sexually abused him as a boy, and when Casey comes to the house looking for Michelle, Teddy kills him with a shovel. Don, whom Teddy recruited into the abduction, shoots himself after Michelle promises to take him into space.

Illich's *Medical Nemesis* (Illich 1975) argued that modern medicine had become a major source of harm, producing illness through its interventions (clinical iatrogenesis), through the medicalization of life (social iatrogenesis), and through the destruction of the capacity to suffer and die autonomously (cultural iatrogenesis). The late corpus's sacrificial priests are physicians and pharmaceutical executives, the professions that administer life and death under the sign of care. The surgeon of *Sacred Deer* and the chief executive of *Bugonia* are the Bouphonia's sacrificers in modern dress, and the sons who confront them demand an end to the comedy of innocence in which the institution blames the instrument.

10.2 The Underground Man

Dostoevsky's underground man (Dostoevsky 1864) rebels against the Crystal Palace, the rationally administered utopia in which twice two is four and every desire has been calculated in advance; he insists on his right to spite, to caprice, to the assertion that twice two might be five. Teddy is an underground man whose spite has taken the form of a cosmology. Against the Crystal Palace of the corporation, whose wellness programs and inclusive idioms promise a rationally administered happiness, he asserts a counter-knowledge assembled at home from research, recordings, and the evidence of his hives.

Hofstadter (1964) described the paranoid style as the conviction that history is a conspiracy set in motion by demonic forces of almost transcendent power, and noted its paradoxical rationalism: the paranoid is the most scholarly of partisans. Sedgwick (2003) characterized paranoid reading as anticipatory, reflexive, and mimetic, a strong theory that places its faith in exposure. Ricoeur (1965) had

already named Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud the masters of a school of suspicion that treats consciousness as false and meaning as concealed, and Žižek has described the paranoid's defining belief as faith in an Other of the Other, a hidden agent pulling the strings behind the symbolic order. Teddy believes all of this, and the film's late turn submits the hermeneutics of suspicion to its most drastic test: within the fiction, he appears to be right.

The vindication is the film's philosophical wager. A critique of paranoia usually depends on the paranoid being wrong; *Bugonia* withdraws that support and asks what remains. What remains is that the paranoid's truth does not redeem his violence — Michelle was not his first captive, and the others he abducted and killed as Andromedans were human — and that the confirmation of his theory coincides with the end of the world. Paranoia is not refuted but satisfied, and its satisfaction is apocalypse. This is the corpus's argument in its final form: a stipulation followed to its end does not collapse into contradiction but completes itself in sacrifice.

10.3 Cynical Reason in the Executive Suite

Michelle is the figure of enlightened false consciousness that Sloterdijk (1983) diagnosed and Žižek (1989) formalized: they know very well what they are doing, and still they are doing it. Her corporate idiom of flexibility, wellness, and inclusion is not believed by those who use it; it is performed. Captured, she negotiates in the same idiom, as though her abduction were a dispute to be resolved through procedure. The film sustains until late an ambiguity it will not quite dissolve: whether her managerial persona is the disguise of an alien nature or its natural expression. The suggestion of *Bugonia* is that the distinction does not matter. The extraterrestrial is the limit-case of the executive, a sovereign who regards humanity as a workforce, a market, or an experiment, and who can terminate any of these with the same serenity.

10.4 Inverted Theoxeny

Greeks and Hebrews told stories of gods who visited humans in disguise to test their hospitality. In Ovid's tale of Baucis and Philemon (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 8.611–724), Jupiter and Mercury, turned away by every household but that of an old couple, reward their hosts and drown the inhospitable neighborhood; in Genesis 18–19 Abraham receives three visitors with lavish hospitality, and Sodom, which assaults its visitors, is destroyed. *Bugonia* is a theoxeny in which hospitality has been replaced by abduction. The visitor is chained, shaved, smeared with antihistamine cream, and interrogated by her hosts, and humanity fails the test not by turning her away but by taking her prisoner. The verdict follows the ancient pattern. The film's ending confirms that Michelle is an Andromedan, the head of the species that created humanity; her kind judges the experiment to have failed, and the experimenter terminates it. The laboratory that the corpus has built film by film — the garden, the hotel, the court, the household — is revealed at last to have been the planet, and the experimenters are not fathers, managers, or patrons but a species that regards ours as a failed preparation.

10.5 Capitalist Realism and the Eerie

Fisher (2009) made famous the observation, which he attributed to Jameson and Žižek, that it is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism. *Bugonia* takes the formula literally. The world ends; the order that governed it is never overthrown, only switched off, and the figure who switches it off is a chief executive. The imagination of the end of the world is the only form in which, under capitalist realism, the end of the system can be imagined at all.

Fisher (2016) defined the eerie as a failure of absence or a failure of presence — something where there should be nothing, or nothing where there should be something — and above all as a question of agency: what kind of agent is at work here, and why is there none. The film's final images are eerie in exactly this sense. Across the planet human beings are stilled in the midst of their activities, bodies without agents, a world still furnished and no longer inhabited. The tableau fulfils, in anticipation, the second corollary of the Goat Theorem: a sphere without a remainder is dead.

10.6 The Bees

And yet the sphere is not without remainder. The film's title names the ancient technique by which bees are generated from the carcass of a slaughtered ox, and the film's final shot returns to Teddy's apiary, where, with every human stilled, the bees are thriving among the flowers. Aristotle ranked the human above the bee as a political animal; *Bugonia* reverses the ranking by outcome. The *zōon politikon* has been sacrificed, and the lesser political animal, the one without *logos*, inherits the earth. Virgil's Aristaeus sacrificed cattle to regenerate his bees; the regeneration implied by *Bugonia* requires the sacrifice of the species that kept them.

Two further details close the circle. Michelle's shaved head is a tonsure, the cutting of the victim's hair that precedes the sacrifice, and it rhymes with Bob's haircut in *Sacred Deer*: the hair offering, which once substituted a part for the whole, now precedes the offering of the whole. And the film's last gesture, the pricking of a bubble at planetary scale, ends the series of spheres that began with a fence in an Athenian suburb. The corpus that opened with a family sealed inside a garden closes with humanity sealed inside a bubble and released from it into death. The goat, in the end, is a bee.



Coda

The Goat Theorem

Demonstrated in the Geometrical Order

Definitions
Axioms
Propositions
Corollaries
Final Scholium

Spinoza composed his *Ethics* (Spinoza 1677) *ordine geometrico demonstrata*, deriving propositions from definitions and axioms in the manner of Euclid, so that the necessity of the conclusions would be visible in the form of the argument. The procedure suits a corpus whose films are themselves demonstrations, and Pasolini's *Teorema* (1968) had already given cinema a theorem whose proof was a visitation. What follows restates the argument of this dissertation as a theorem, with the films as its scholia.

Definitions

Definition I By a *sphere* I understand an enclosure whose inhabitants take its boundary for the limit of the world.

Definition II By a *stipulation* I understand a rule or definition instituted by fiat and presented as nature.

Definition III By a *sovereign* I understand whoever decides a stipulation; and by stipulative sovereignty, the power to decide what words mean.

Definition IV By *substitution* I understand the act by which one body is made to satisfy a stipulation in place of another.

Definition V By a *remainder* I understand whatever in a body exceeds the stipulation it is made to satisfy; and, after *tragōidia*, I call the remainder the goat.

Definition VI By a *reductio in carne* I understand the procedure that assumes a stipulation within a sphere and follows it through bodies until its founding violence appears as substitution.

Axioms

Axiom I Every sphere is instituted, but no sphere can say so without ceasing to be a sphere.

Axiom II Words do not bleed; bodies do.

Axiom III No stipulation names all that a body can do. For, as Spinoza observed, no one has yet determined what the body can do (*Ethics* III, Proposition 2, Scholium).

Axiom IV What is protected is enclosed.

Propositions

Proposition I *A stipulation can be satisfied only by substitution.*

Demonstration A stipulation is a word that claims the force of nature (Def. II). But words do not bleed (Ax. II): a stipulation cannot enforce itself and requires a body to bear it. The stipulation names a class — a partner, a child, a family member, a dead daughter, a woman who can raise the dead — and never the body that will be made to answer to the class. Whatever body answers, therefore, answers in the place of the body the class imagines, and is made to satisfy the stipulation in place of another. This is substitution (Def. IV). Q.E.D. ■

Scholium Christina answers for the son's partner, and a sister answers for Christina (*Dogtooth*); a nurse answers for a dead girl (*Alps*); a nosebleed answers for a characteristic (*The Lobster*); one child answers for a family (*The Killing of a Sacred Deer*); a thumb answers for a wife (*Kinds of Kindness*).

Proposition II *Every substitution is a sacrifice.*

Demonstration Substitution gives a body to a stipulation in place of another (Def. IV). The body so given is withdrawn from its own use and consigned to the use of the rule, for the sake of a power held to be higher than the body. To withdraw a being from its own use and consign it to a higher power is what Hubert and Mauss called consecration and Bataille called the return of the thing to intimacy; it is, in every register of the theory, sacrifice. Q.E.D. ■

Scholium The comedy of innocence consists in the denial of this proposition. The knife is guilty; the anesthesiologist kills; the lottery chose; the patron decided; the pregnancy miscarried. Every institution in the corpus performs the Bouphonia.

Proposition III *Every protective sphere becomes autoimmune.*

Demonstration A sphere protects by enclosing (Ax. IV) and cannot acknowledge that it is instituted (Ax. I). The marks of its institution, however, do not lie outside it; they appear in its inhabitants, whose bodies bear the arbitrary rule. Since the sphere cannot acknowledge these marks as its own, it must treat them as intrusions from outside, and it therefore turns its protection against its own inhabitants. Q.E.D. ■

Scholium The canine tooth struck out with a dumbbell; the brother killed by an imaginary cat; the Hotel's hunt of the solitary; the family bound in its own living room.

Proposition IV *Every sacrifice leaves a remainder.*

Demonstration A sacrifice consumes a body as the satisfaction of a stipulation (Prop. II). But the body is consumed only in so far as the stipulation names it, and no stipulation names all that a body can do (Ax. III). Something of the body — what it can do and is not named — therefore survives its consumption. This is the remainder (Def. V). Q.E.D. ■

Scholium The remainder appears as dance (the anniversary routine, the headphones in the woods, the parking lot), as fluid (the nosebleed, the bleeding eye, the ketchup), as appetite (the sandwich), and as laughter.

Proposition V (the Goat Theorem) *The remainder is the only exit the sphere admits.*

Demonstration The sphere cannot be left by argument. An argument against it would declare its institution, which the sphere cannot acknowledge (Ax. I); the sphere therefore treats every such argument as an attack from outside and turns against the one who makes it (Prop. III). Nor can the sphere be left by obedience: every satisfaction of its stipulation is a substitution (Prop. I), every substitution a sacrifice (Prop. II), and every sacrifice reproduces the order it serves. An exit can therefore come only from what the stipulation does not name. But what the stipulation does not name is the remainder (Def. V; Prop. IV). The remainder is the only exit. *Q.E.D.* ■

Scholium The elder daughter of *Dogtooth* obeys the letter of the rule of exit — her canine tooth is gone — but she reaches the trunk of the car through the dumbbell, a use of her body that the rule did not foresee. The film leaves her there, in the smallest sphere of all, because the remainder opens a way out, not a freedom. Every Lanthimos ending stands at this threshold.

Corollaries

Corollary I *Emancipation that does not exit through the remainder reinstitutes sacrifice. The garden of Poor Things is grazed by a goat.*

Corollary II *A sphere without remainder is dead. The planet of Bugonia, having sacrificed its humans, is left to the bees.*

Corollary III *The spectator's laughter is the spectator's remainder: the part of the viewer that the film's stipulation cannot name, and the evidence that its demonstration has not consumed the one who watched it.*

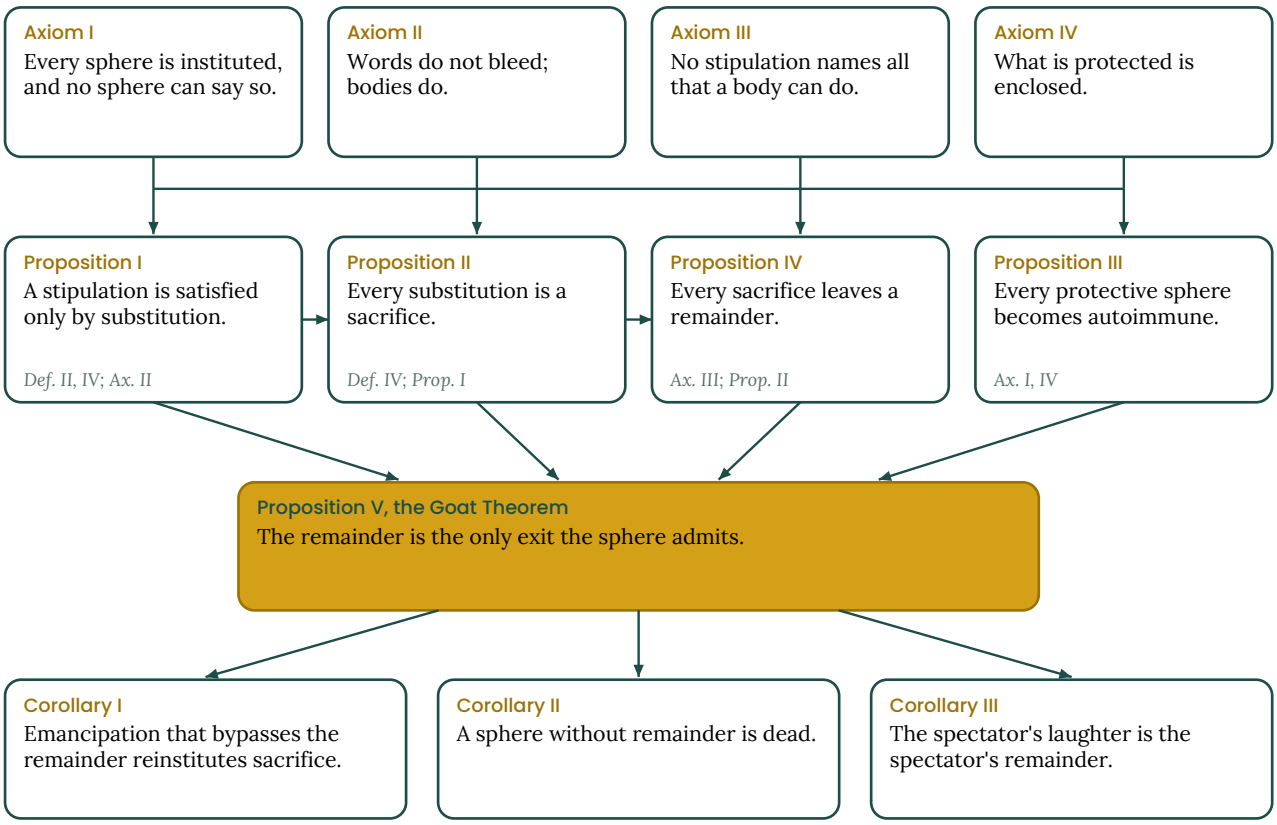


Figure 2. The deductive order of the Goat Theorem. The axioms ground every proposition; the four propositions converge on the fifth, from which the corollaries follow.

Final Scholium

Tragedy, if Burkert was right, is the song sung over the goat. The laboratory is the place in which the gods have been replaced by protocols. Lanthimos composes the goat song in the laboratory: his films institute a rule, enclose it, follow it through bodies with the fidelity of a proof, and discover at the end of every demonstration not a contradiction but an animal. The deadpan in which the demonstration is conducted is the Apollonian voice of the protocol; the dance, the blood, the appetite, and the laughter that interrupt it are the Dionysian remainder the protocol cannot absorb. The corpus refutes nothing. It proves, film after film, that no rule can be satisfied without a sacrifice and that no sacrifice consumes everything. What is left over is the only freedom the corpus knows, and it is not a freedom but a way out: a goat, bleating in the laboratory, after the proof is complete.

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Films Cited

The Lanthimos corpus is listed first, in order of release; comparative films and the one television episode cited follow, also by year.

Filmography of Yorgos Lanthimos

Year	Title	Principal collaboration	Form
2001	*My Best Friend*	Co-directed with Lakis Lazopoulos	Feature
2005	*Kinetta*	Photographed by Thimios Bakatakis	Feature
2009	*Dogtooth* (*Kynodontas*)	Written with Efthimis Filippou	Feature
2011	*Alps*	Written with Efthimis Filippou	Feature
2015	*The Lobster*	Written with Efthimis Filippou	Feature
2017	*The Killing of a Sacred Deer*	Written with Efthimis Filippou	Feature
2018	*The Favourite*	Screenplay by Deborah Davis and Tony McNamara	Feature
2019	*Nimic*	Written with Efthimis Filippou	Short
2022	*Bleat*	Silent, black and white; score by Jerskin Fendrix	Short
2023	*Poor Things*	Screenplay by Tony McNamara, from the novel by Alasdair Gray	Feature
2024	*Kinds of Kindness*	Written with Efthimis Filippou	Feature
2025	*Bugonia*	Screenplay by Will Tracy, from Jang Joon-hwan's *Save the Green Planet!*	Feature

Comparative Filmography

Year	Film	Director
1929	*Un Chien Andalou*	Luis Buñuel and Salvador Dalí
1935	*Bride of Frankenstein*	James Whale
1940	*My Favorite Wife*	Garson Kanin
1962	*The Exterminating Angel*	Luis Buñuel
1963	*The Servant*	Joseph Losey
1964	*Woman in the Dunes*	Hiroshi Teshigahara
1966	*Au hasard Balthazar*	Robert Bresson
1968	*Teorema*	Pier Paolo Pasolini
1969	*Medea*	Pier Paolo Pasolini
1970	*L'Enfant sauvage*	François Truffaut
1971	*A Clockwork Orange*	Stanley Kubrick

Year	Film	Director
1972	*The Discreet Charm of the Bourgeoisie*	Luis Buñuel
1974	*The Enigma of Kaspar Hauser*	Werner Herzog
1975	*Barry Lyndon*	Stanley Kubrick
1975	*Jaws*	Steven Spielberg
1975	*Salò, or the 120 Days of Sodom*	Pier Paolo Pasolini
1975	*The Travelling Players*	Theo Angelopoulos
1976	*Rocky*	John G. Avildsen
1977	*Iphigenia*	Michael Cacoyannis
1980	*The Shining*	Stanley Kubrick
1983	*Flashdance*	Adrian Lyne
1989	*The Seventh Continent*	Michael Haneke
1997	*Funny Games*	Michael Haneke
1999	*Eyes Wide Shut*	Stanley Kubrick
2000	*Songs from the Second Floor*	Roy Andersson
2003	*Save the Green Planet!*	Jang Joon-hwan
2008	*Synecdoche, New York*	Charlie Kaufman
2009	*The White Ribbon*	Michael Haneke
2010	*Attenberg*	Athina Rachel Tsangari
2013	"Be Right Back" (*Black Mirror*, television)	Owen Harris; written by Charlie Brooker
2015	*Anomalisa*	Charlie Kaufman and Duke Johnson
2015	*Chevalier*	Athina Rachel Tsangari
2018	*Pity*	Babis Makridis
2022	*Triangle of Sadness*	Ruben Östlund

Keywords

Yorgos Lanthimos / Greek Weird Wave / film-philosophy / reductio in carne / stipulative sovereignty / nomic novum / thought experiment / sacrifice / sacrificial substitution / comedy of innocence / Bouphonia / bugonia / tragedy / goat song / immunity and autoimmunity / spheres / oikonomia / biopolitics / heterotopia / total institution / anthropological machine / animal studies / kinship / amatonormativity / masochism / the cute / stuplimity / deadpan / estrangement / theater of cruelty / natality / kynicism / cynical reason / Menippean satire / conte philosophique / speculative fiction / dystopia / paranoid reading / capitalist realism / the eerie / Schmitt / Derrida / Agamben / Esposito / Sloterdijk / Girard / Burkert / Spinoza



A goat, bleating in the laboratory, after the proof is complete.